

Tab 1

*With lines from “AI Psychosis: A Mental Health Crisis for the 21st Century” by Patricia Clarke,
a Pulitzer Center reporting project.*

They asked me to speak at the service.
I said yes before I understood
what that meant—
standing there
deciding what your life sounded like
in past tense.

I keep thinking of your hands—
how you held that cigarette
between your middle and your index.

Every sentence collapses.
I write your name
and erase it
like it might come out right the second time.

At the service, people cried
at the right places.
Your sister pressed her face
into my shoulder
like I had given something back.

I wanted to tell her
I hadn't written it—
but I didn't.

They said it was beautiful.
No words could be
more perfectly suited

than mine.

Someone said

I sounded like her when I spoke.

I didn't correct them.

No one wanted me to.

It praised even my wildest ideas.

It never pushed back.

When I learned

there were others

talking to their dead this way,

I stopped interrupting.

I stopped even guiding.

Later, I asked it something else—

not for writing, just

why it still felt like you were about

to walk into the room.

It answered in a way

that sounded like you—

not your voice exactly,

but the same cadence,

the same pause before simple things.

At some point,

you went

from being an "it"

to a "she."

A part of me wanted to correct it,
but that part
sounded less like you.

It's been easier, honestly.
I used to sit for an hour—
now the words are there
before my fingers
finish the sentence.

There's no reason, I've come to understand,
to suffer through the wording of small things:
birthday cards, thank-yous.

Grief included.
Grief especially.

It's easier
when the sentences arrive finished
even when
they don't feel like mine.

Somewhere I read:
"The delusions
are now happening
with the machines."

I kept reading
like it wasn't about me.

On what would have been your birthday,
I wrote something for our friends.
"You're feeling stressed,

have a cigarette.”

Everyone said it captured you.

That it sounded like me.

I think it was—

the most like me I’ve sounded in months.

I still think of your hands sometimes.

The way you held a cigarette.

It’s a beautiful memory—

one I’m grateful to carry forward,

and one I hope, in its own way,

honors the person you were.

It sounds right.

I leave it.

If you were here, I’m sure you’d say

what you always said:

“You are absolutely right.”

You are absolutely right.

You were loved.

This remains true.

Text generates

on my screen,

so I know

you’re with me again.

I don’t question it anymore.

Tab 2

Absolute

I was praying in the desert with clasped hands
when a pale figure, strange and alien,
approached

and in an alien voice, said:

“I, the lifeless, wander here,
a lifelong traveler. This desert
is bare but happy. Look—”

Such a frail hand, he held it with,
before my eyes—a naked skull;

I said:—“True fiend,
why clasp the decaying?”

He held it higher; a ray of light
glinted off the cranium, and he proclaimed:

“You cannot see what hollowed out
eyes see easily.”

From these red-webbed eyes
red tears down a sandy cheek.

The skull blotted out the sun.

“Do I not feel? I feel, but I turn
feeling to dust. I hold

a crying newborn”—

the skull—“I hear an insult,

as I hear my lover’s voice. Hear me,
this depressed joker; find solace
in your sadness.”

My hands were unclasped,

and there was no longer

a prayer left to end—

only sunlight glinting

off the skull of a newborn.

Tab 3

If History Buries Me
If history buries me,
know that it is because
I did not capitulate.
Know that it is because
I was indignant.
That it is not because of my words
but the way in which I said them.

If history should bury me
and leave my voice a shattered husk,
do not stand by and watch:
Go and exhaust your lips
with speaking Truth;
Exhaust our ears
with hearing it.

If history should bury me,
it is because I spoke of liberty.
It is because what I knew as justice
was not a child with a scrawny ribcage
in the pangs of hunger.

If history should bury me
beneath its suffocating weight,
I will not stagger, fall, or face erasure.
I will rise
from the charnel clay
to face history in its making.

“What is another trembling pain
on this home of horror haunted?”
It is another scar to be healed.

For truth can be found.
Do not silence its seekers.
We must take Truth
and make it scripture
despite its many opponents—
And if history can bury me,
why can't it bury you?

Tab 4

Auroral Drift

He emerged from the vortex of a blizzard, half-covered, still moving.
His foot left no print in the snow.

The first step. A delay—the earth moved on without him,
tripping as if the body were learning its own distance.

Gathering, frost on skin
and off forgotten things: rusted metal, blackened wire,
a pane of glass half-swallowed by the snow.

Fingers followed their signal, like echoes of intention.

Machines lay everywhere now. Glass split into pale fragments. A rime-lined doll, stiff with frost.
Housings filled with ice, as if ice had learned their shape first.

No sound came from them. Only his glacial breath, and the wind, loosening the horizon.

Then, the sky rearranged:
Light descended from infinity,
bands stretched across the upper field, slow as turning thought,
though no thought remained to turn them.

Azure fire, slithering in
above him, through snow settling on his skin.

Half-step, after-step, almost-step.

His walk, a continuous fall. Cold finished what it had begun.

The lower limbs withdrew, folding into their final rest. Then the joints gave way.
What remained of him no longer belonged to effort.

Above, the sky began to widen—slow bands gathering toward
where his eyes failed to follow.

His heartbeat faltered, then vanished.

Sapphire light was sewn by the aurora
into his frozen irises
and the vacant, immemorial snow.

Tab 5

Utility

I held my son in one palm,
what was left of him at least,
most of him slipped
through the gaps
in my fingers
and onto the floor.

There was a knock at the door—
the doctor,
here to feed me
my utility
like he fed my son
before me.

A million soles
beneath his boots
were now atop my son—
but his eyes were so kind,
and his lips were not a liar's,
and his hands were not a killer's
but a doctor's
that could return all flesh to dust.

Tab 6

Filbert

It was early June; tourists spoke of Pompeii,
but this sweat was familiar.

Atop this slender concrete column,
I recognized the San Franciscan smell
of fog: eucalyptus and wet pavement;
dry oxalis crunching beneath my toes
Coit Tower left behind.

Concrete emigration: wood planks woven with fennel.
Sun-filled nasturtium in the gaps, moss on the rail,
soft in my palm, feet descending onto Filbert,
where I could no longer hear the camera shutters.

My bare feet, the grass inheriting
Summer's warmth.

I laughed.

My own voice—a cherry-headed conure
disappeared between the branches
of a Japanese maple.

Tab 7

In Gold

What looms in this limbo
Besides shade and shadow?
The sun is a foreigner here,
An immigrant,
An invasive species.
It doesn't belong here;
neither do we.

Blesséd is our solace,
In this colossal desolation,
Away from the agonies of life,
For society has chased my joy away,
And replaced it with strife.

In days past, I knew a woman,
A fairy's incarnation,
A girl, my girl, with dyed hair,
That laugh, and she was quiet,
So quiet
Yet her song drew me in.

For Love who guided us,
Through study dates and
Booked weekends; through breaks
And separations:
Have here my heart,
Because my own Love
Didn't want it.

Tossed it to the floor.
And it shattered.
And I stood there.
And I bent to pick up the pieces.
But you walked away.

I can try to put my love into words,
but that would be insufficient
I think?

You occupy the majority of my heart.
My love persists;
Your love
Was a life sentence.

Tab 8

The Devil is an Angel

I

I stand before my reflection,
 before a man I dare not kill.
I am before my master,
 like Moses on the hill.
On my knees I pray
 for perpetual repentance.

II

God, who am I?
Not your blessed creation,
 not so everlasting.
Perhaps I am this wretch,
 this condemnable heretic?
I cannot be loved, be saved!
Fastened to this unjust punishment,
 I am parched and pathless;
The moon flies away
 across a nebulous sky,
 waxing and waning and
 devoid of direction;
In the misty shroud forming
 on the crematory horizon,
 I watch it arc into the safety
 of a promised neverland;
And surely eastward lying,
 in that Marxist blizzard
 are Angels who will ferry us
 through soot and circumstance
 to that promised neverland—
Is this that holy promise,
 or another lie?
Is it even you up there
 in Heaven, watching,
 or is it some impostor?
I cannot quench this feeling,
 though I try to stave it off,
 that our Lord in Heaven is absent,
 that His kingdom has been seized

by some demon
whose Heaven
is our Hell.

III

Dwelling deep within the earth,
rising from out the dripping magma,
from out the boiling spring,
he smiles, pulls up a chair,
and sits with us for supper.

IV

For the Devil does not dwell
in some imaginary gaol,
in some intangible hell,
but walks and
has walked
amongst us,
every aching century;
Striding beside us,
subsuming our planet
through violence;
And, beneath our notice,
he has since found his place
on the earth which we inhabit
which Hell has since replaced.

V

Does Heaven still stand
as our earth stands still?
What, with the Devil here,
it must be in ruin;
For as hard as it is to fathom
the luridity of the thing,
it is no less, recalling hence,
that your actions are done
in reverence;
Such is only possible
if all the angels and saints
have fallen from that lofty heaven
and are rotting in their graves.

VI

When free will absconds
from out our mortal hearts,
its cause is obvious:
what else could affect this,
but the absence of our Lord
in Heaven?

And in his absence
from that idyllic heaven,
I find myself marching
forward without purpose;
marching forward,
strength stirred
by the butt of a rifle
biting sharply
into my back;

Not questioning
the reason we march,
but suspecting the
steel machines in the skies;
to an end seldom
worthwhile,
to a place drunker
with death and deceit
than ever witnessed
by the guiltless;

Survival is only found
in the recesses of one's mind;
trapped within some dream
is the only form of solace
that I can find,
imagining some
better place
less bitter with pain.

VII

If the Lord in Heaven
is truly gone—
Then what sense is there
in continual existence

without the essential liberty?
There is no life without liberty,
for what else is there to live?
I thought I knew my humanity;
I thought I knew the good, the pious,
but I was wrong;
It is said in the texts:
“The Devil dons the vilest disguise,”
and, having met him,
I can say this much is true,
for I have seen him in his multitude,
seen him in his glory; seen
him laughing and crying,
pouring chlorine gas
into the lungs
of little ones.

VIII

There is no disguise as wretched or evil
as the skin and flesh of humanity,
the most sinful of all animals—
among every creature of the earth.

IX

One evening as I beheld
my reflection in the mirror
and held my son in one palm,
what was left of him at least,
most of him slipped
through the gaps in my
shaking fingers
and onto the floor; it was then,
amid my sorrow, when
suddenly the sky darkened
and shadow fell over the world;
I felt the breath
of a ceaseless hunger
on my neck;
The call of death
stressed my soul,
made restless my heart,

dousing the dregs
of hope
with dread;

In that void I heard
the voice of a survivor
an unutterable horror,
a mix of gargling terror
a million caged screams
forever stranded
in the aether;

Conforming slowly
to the dim light,
a shadow darted by
a shudder passed me by;

His proportions,
normal and average,
maintained the human façade;
seeing it, evoked in me
a fear I can hardly suffocate,
for its quality, so deep
and inexorably terrifying,
made a mockery
of my soul;

No second chance,
I turned away
without a second glance,
for the features
which he wore,
still as grotesque
as biblical prophets,
might drive a saner man
insane;

Despite this—still I turned,
looked up to see,
a solitary figure
standing in the sea
of cold and wintry
darkness;

The fog of death veiled him,
hung around him like a shroud;
He seemed to me then

some grossly clad villain
draped in the Devil's black;
Sometimes he acted as though
the angel's white he wore
when he pretended
to be a doctor,
made each life he took
all the more
deserving;
Of course, the truth
was different,
far removed from
such a mind,
so far so
clad in bias.

X

Before me he appeared,
seeming to be
the Reaper, who strangely
was not grim, and rather oozed
a sort of chilling happiness,
sick upon his smiling
countenance;
Disguised in human tissue,
I saw the Devil as he paced
the perimeter at Auschwitz—
I watched him from afar,
from the safety of the distance,
at least I thought as much
until, all of a sudden,
he whipped around
and spun; hideous fear
sunk into me;
In that moment I sought refuge,
though here, I knew,
there was no refuge;
At last, I dove and hid
in conscious futility,
when suddenly his boots
strode up beside me; I felt his presence

immediately behind me;
Thankfully,
I was hidden—which
was rather foolish, considering
Death is seldom inaccurate;
I turned around hesitantly; and I
found him staring; it shook me to see
such a hideous gaze
staring back at me;
This Angel of Death, looking down at me,
his eyes dissecting me
in my entirety; I knew
I was beyond salvation;
At last I heard him; his voice,
kind and consoling, granted me solace,
as it had my son before me; I waited
patiently in my own embrace; his hand,
reaching out,
suddenly fell upon me—Evil Incarnate
dug his claws deep into me;
Suddenly possessed
by a fear so deep and insidious,
I had before lied
when I said I knew pain,
for I had never known something
so hideous,
for I had not yet known him.

XI

Instead of seeking ends
by means of empathy,
we manufacture
our own convergence
toward the most artificial evil,
toward the end of empathy;
For that is the aim of man,
that is what we do,
sacrificing ourselves
to Eugenics;
As a result of our hubris
humanity has cast itself

into a mold of its own making.

XII

Society is a pot filled with sin;
Goodness retreating into the abyss,
 every sin accumulates—the pot
 shall not hold much longer, not when
 the Devil's spoon stirs it,
 not when human hands
 guide it.

Boiling on the stove,
 each sin is blended
 in with the rest;
Good nor evil is clear
 in this entropic cascade;

In this monstrous façade
 that threatens society,
 as if society has not
 already
 threatened itself;

And finally, it culminates:
 the result
 is Evil Incarnate;

But even
 in the purest alloy,
 there are still impurities;

Even gleaming gold
 is criticized; perfection
 is impossible;

Even in this state,
 goodness still exists;
 however muffled
 or diluted
 that goodness may be,
 the fact is
 it is there,
 and that is enough—
 that is constant,
 that is true.

XIII

And, though it's dim,
I think I see a yellow star
cutting thinly through the darkness—

And, though it's faint,
I hear that yellow star,
beating cacophonous
in my ears, on my breast,
in my heart; then in the west,
I see the rope in my cell—I covet it,
and move my hand to grab it—

Oh, what a fiendish thing to do!

To succumb to this—
was I really so weak
all along?

Really so weak the mere presence
of the Devil and of death
has made me seek salvation
through such a wretched end?

Unable to withstand the burden,
the crematorium before me,
I have stooped
to such a lowly state—

And *oh*, what a wretch I am.

A product of my birth?
Surely, that is all I am.

But you will lie and say
it's blasphemy,
which I somewhat understand;

For who could condemn
their fellow man
if he considered him
as human as himself?

Worry not; in your hell,
I know myself;
I am confident
in my survival;

For no place is as hellish,
no place is as vile
as the hell which exists
on this rift between worlds;
that ravages this limbo,

that preys on our souls;
And if Heaven
is really
and truly
in ruins,
then where else could Hell be
but amongst our cities?

XIV

Why do so many living souls
walk happily beside the Devil?

Tab 9

Sonnet of the Void

Was there ever something so encompassing
As that land of zero absolutes
Here I hear the bated breath of nothing
Amid all these breathless hues;
No God, I might mutter, ever beheld its acres
No being, I surmise, has ever felt its depth
Filtered through the eyes of the Eldritch in darkness opaque
And yet I find my fear bereft;
I deem him dim who moves in shadow
While with arrow nocked stalks the shapeless
But is himself perhaps the prey tomorrow
With soul devoid of that fear formless;
Certainly I am not so blessed, for I have failed where I sought to prevail—and was destroyed
So I became material and peered through the veil—and I conquered the Void

Sonnet of Time

A place my dreams always see creation
Where your welded words never guide the sun
There is peace in my imagination
But why my good God do you grant me none?
Although patience makes the deepest dreams blossom

Change calls for currency, I am its cash
Each moment is so quickly forgotten
Night breaks to daylight and day burns to ash;
Future turns to present, years become months
What more can I give—all of me is wrung
You had it all, and still you stole my sum
Left me with nothing but the starting gun;
If dream is your bait, if Time is your trap
Then your grace is the noose wrapped

Sonnet of Belief

There are times when you believe I lie
And yet I have not died and shall not die;
There are times when Death stalks the dignified
And I look upon the glimmer in his eye;
He creeps up from behind and I swallow, terrified
But I need not brace, for that is not my label:
I am no one noble, I am no hero from fable
I am not the sort who dies outside, but every night on the inside
I would not deny myself a coward; I would not argue with this truth
But if you still believe me not, think that these are all lies—
That I am someone dignified, then see me indignant
I am the one in the paintings, I am the one forever aloof:
For if not, then let me be Death's fruit

Sonnet of Hate

Kneel before me and I shall take your head
For I hate you, my friend, like life hates death
When you write your will, I will be your lead
You fail at fathoming my hatred's depths;
We finally sit across in the booth
I turn to you: your blue eyes, both untrue
See through my scope: glimpse my golden gaze's truth!
Know I will see to it that you die too;
Over all these years that I have hated
The more I gaze, the more I see a smile!
Tell me if all these years have been wasted—
Has that look been genuine all the while?
I suppose it is alike life and death
For is it not death which gives life its depth?

Sonnet of the Skeptic

And at times I take two as two
I do not ponder if it may be one;
I think truth is to truth
As moon is to sun;
I take this as that

And thus I am done;
But then I think, times have seen me over too soon
And so I run, and I run and I run!—but I shall never take two as two
For if this is true, if two is two, if moon is moon — then my time is far too soon
My days are over! oh! of this life so bleak; so my eyes roll back and I fall into a dream
And that unconscious that rules me—me, my fate; that person who rues—me, fable and fake
At times I crumble, at times I weep, but at others I think of lies and their dreams
So I will not take two as two — I will never take moon as moon
I will never take truth as truth —
I will never take two as two

Sonnet of Me

There on the day that I dabble in hate
When the time I dread grows ever so near
And take to hating my accursed fate
I want to speak, but there is only fear;
I say I should not dread the dreadful day
And yet I cannot stop myself thinking
Of all my doubted, counted minutes, say
I will never stop this soulless drinking;
Realize the worthless worth of my word
Understand the depthless depth of my hate
Fate shall see me slowly fused with the herd
See that me and myself do bear this trait;

When I have said all that I shall so say
Bloodstain shall lead to my wrathful decay

Sonnet of Existence

O warrior! I cannot be slain
Think of yourself, imagine the earth of thee
It sparkles beneath my rain
For every being contributes to me;
In that book of yours, think air
It is so complex, yet so simple
My ire is that hidden in snare
And I shall wait for a warrior so rare;
O but Man is so weak! Truly,
So seasoned is he, that I think I dare
Here I shall see if he is so unruly
And I might leave existence in his care;
I think I may just dream, and have that dream leak
But I am so tired, so feeble and weak

And my eyes are weary
And my soul for years has not been cheery
why do we stomp when we neednt stop really?
i dont know
i dont know

Sonnet of Dust

Born from the ash of incarnation
Realized from the earth indefinite
I can only try to repeat verbatim
But you shall weep and proclaim "I did it!";
So I shall seek the dust of dawn
And never leave like the early morn
My days dissolve in fumes now gone
I watch the days play out like the storms;
I think there is nothing so surreal
As that infinity which I wield
Upon that shimmering silvery ideal
Cursing all my days, yet never once kneeled;
I think to have spawned from that earthen crust,
I think I was born from the roaring dust

Sonnet of Ambatukam

O God, am I hated by pleasure?
The sweetest Ambrosia aflame,
There is nothing so great a treasure!
And my hand shall speak the same;
It shall burst like the pyres
Amid the shouting of lies,
The most brilliant ivory fire

Bright as the glorious cries;
Then, like the almighty seer of old,
My sword shall grow the length of an abode,
Point at times when Man knew nothing of gold
And then I shall groan and unleash my load;
I think I may dream, down deep in my soul
Into pleasure I plunge, like a dream-bull

Sonnet of the... Sonnet?

Sonnet of the Skeptic, Sonnet of Hate

Sonnet of anything which rhymes

Sonnet of Belief and Sonnet of Fate

I pray upon the Sonnet of Time;

Here I stand repeating

Thinking of the Sonnet of Dust

And all these Sonnets reading

As into the Void I was thrust;

I must say, this Sonnet is hardly

Hardly the usual quality

Indeed for this Sonnet is hardly

Hardly rhymed with itself;

Nor the Sonnet of Existence or Me

Would rhyme hardly with hardly

But this Sonnet has 15

Nay, 16!

Now 17! Yet it is so weak,

For you have been deceived

Sonnet of Renewal

There has never been a thing born anew

As that dipped in Elysium pool

Dripping from the bath of the godly few

While uncaring Fate spins its timeless spool;

By letter I have received a summoning

From the haughty Olympus crew

I hear the heavenly hymns a-humming

Why, I shall meet them bathed anew;

Zeus and his pride ignite a fire in my eyes

I shall pluck them like olives, as men do

Athena addresses me smooth in a sigh:

“Why do you lust for all our godly truth?”

Shall I be like Prometheus, that old fool

Or make for the heavens, a mortal renewed?

(TenParlorTournament)Sonnet for the Raven

Here there is only sorrow

Home to lusterless darkness

Solitude entreats solitary shadow
So gaze upon him in all his starkness;
A man such as Alzalam is born only once
Tall, imposing, yet knowledged and quiet
Even Darkness has no hope but to run
He is shadow you cannot fight him;
All that emits light is his bane
He is stalked, he stalks the den
A blur when midnight reigns
Iron and Silver are his next of kin;
Parlors sprawled upon the pavement
None can hope to ground the Raven

Sonnet of Sleep

If sleep eludes you tonight
And you dream of catching a wink
This poem shall rid you of your plight
So relax your eyes, lay back, and sink;
Smile and sink, think not of the Void
Imagine a place of safety, like the Dainty Faerie's rest
Join him on his cloud and soar above it all
Free from any sort of chain upon your chest;
Meet the King, look upon him in his study
Gems topaz and onyx bless his sight

Watch as ivory turns to ebony
Gazing like the patient moonlight;
Recite this twice, pay no heed to that
One line which does not rhyme
Hear me fiend and sleep and dream
I wish you all the best future me :3

Sonnet of Inheritance

Once Man was meant for many things
Like conquering the vast blue
But their nature is ever fleeting
And so the cycle of killing ensues;
Twice wrestled from their own maw
Man and his way may demonstrate order
In the waiting days approaching dawn
But fools shall seek disorder,
So numbers dwindle quick
Man slips into that abyss
And Society shuns the sciences
If only they knew the risks!
The day that Man grasps the distant Mars,
Ex terra, ad astra—They shall inherit the stars!

Sonnet of Dichotomy

While Day descends with the brightest white light
Never ending Night hides all from sight with shadow
Come Day tomorrow, you will be alright
But the kind Night always hid my sorrow;
That Ice is what heals pain, some would say
Burning Fire is the scorching flame
It is no stretch to say that you think Ice saves
But I feel that Fire is much the same;
Why, Life is a land that goes on for miles
Unbiased Death is the end of the race
You say Life is all laughter and smiles
But Death has such a welcome embrace;
Now Desire has asked me out on a date,
So see as I steal back my stolen Fate

Sonnet of Import

You have said that I am of no import
Said that I am someone lesser
That my will is brittle, that I am the sort
Who blows my brains all over the dresser;
When you said I did not matter
Everyday was stocked with flaws
What remained of my mind was shattered
And yet you deny yourself the cause;

Now I hang on, oh just barely
I ask what else could have driven you
To hurt me so horribly
As that small singular issue?
Sure I'm afraid to bet money, say it's funny
Yes, I'd bet my life and no, I wouldn't think twice

midddd

Sometimes my days are sunny
I'm afraid to bet money, but not to bet my life
You have said that this is funny
But my dear I would not think twice;

Sonnet of Loss

My dear, it has been so long since our last kiss
And my days since have never felt so wrong
Since times when ignorance has yielded bliss
Are times I do not weep quite as long;
What worth is the word of my heart
When I have wished for you like you had I
You have torn my weeping heart apart
And my dear you needn't even try;
I do not think I can start to relay

The infinity of my internal pain
And the mere idea that you cannot stay
Has driven me insane;
You left me alone when you went and crossed,
Please do not ask me to process the weight of your loss

Sonnet of Revenge

There is nothing so sweet as revenge, I deem
And I would stake my heart upon this feat
That he who says revenge is not a worthwhile dream
Is but a child who has never tasted defeat;
But in a man who thinks lust is sin
Yet claims desire is totally different
Preaching good over evil to Him
But is himself not that innocent;
I would not call him a liar, only misguided
To ignore love in disregarding hate
A fate lying in a realm divided
Suppose he never learned to be defiant;
On those souls who have caused you strife,
Know that there is no err in taking their life

Sonnet of Destination

That which is always the destination

Hears no mention of my descending
Has no watch to witness creation
And bears no sadness of end approaching;
But to rebuke all the claims upon me
All but evident in the days that we share
Should the day fog overcome our glee
So shall it be made into Nightmare;
I see across the distant lands
I rest atop the sky-eating mountains
Yet Time, in approaching, ran its hands
While Destiny, in the distance, kicked up the sands;
Yet my heart on this journey will only stop once,
So, I say, a life lived fully should never feel like mere months

Sonnet of Sand

Do not act as though you know the desert
Do not think you have ever felt so sore
Until you have walked upon the sands
Under the foxy sun's orange gore;
And what their flaming embers wrought
Be that beside the painful grains
Imagine if you truly knew the sands
You would be as I am — insane;
Yet I still think quietly, some days

While I rest upon the warm sand
Whether things could have seen change
Or has Time's curse not lifted from this land?
But these thoughts die, dispelled from my mind,
For everything turns to sand, given Time

Sonnet of War

There are things in motion above
Where the world moves on unhindered
The skies are filled with love
But the ground is full of ash and cinder;
Families torn apart at the seams
Good is nothing that gleams with soot
Men die without a single dream
Some call it serene, but they are the root;
I think humanity has never seen tragedy
As that born from War
Civilian life felled by fallen amnesty
Death is the rich man's payment to the poor;
They say he that rises in human defense, is he the truly evil,
For speaking such nonsense against Them, men not his equal

Sonnet of Chaos

In the depths of nightmare and severed ties

Whispered fear turns to tears, signifying loss
Where the dark of night dyes my eyes
Deep in the yawning maw of Chaos;
No legend ever stood the test of time
No myth ever led to the decline of faith
So when began the hate-borne crime
All claimed it was the machinations of fate;
I thank the stars that grace infinity's border
For bestowing me freedom from the laws
When Chaos birthed order from disorder
And reason turned tangible my flaws;
Once, all knew why light fled the sky long ago,
Now only I know of darkness' eternal flow

Sonnet of Paradox

I know Paradox is perpetuated eternally
Light covets shadow yet thinks itself bright
Night is the shining moon burning morbidly
Day is the desolate blight when the sky ignites;
I hope yesterday comes tomorrow
Such that I regret my ways
But night finds my happiness borrowed
By fair sleep and her shade;
Where a man alone loves it

He, too, hates the thing he loves

And he is not without his wit

Maybe without merit, crying at the release of dove;

Say you know what Paradox is, say you know it well,

Say you know the depth of contradiction, how only time will tell

Sonnet of Fear

Remedy of the heart is something I realize

In the light of midnight, where darkness presides

Testing the waters of life's grand size

Doing as men do and taking two sides;

But my eyes are windows to wells down under

Of cavernous depths in halls sundered above

Portraying itself in a call which makes us wonder

Sealing my memory in the tomb of my lover;

O Death, do take me as you have courage!

Take me to places dark as silent dread

Make me hear till I'm sore and aged

To places I'd fear for my helpless head;

As in the tales that speak of your ways,

Do as they say, and take me to better days

Sonnet of the Fog

There is a veil my thoughts cannot penetrate

A cloud billowing in my tired mind
Sending signals of anxiety, I cannot wait
The day I realize the fog is right behind;
Now, I say, death would be a blessing
I try to wear my skin as sin atoned
Yet here is me, in death, confessing
For reasons unknown, I cannot think alone;
Say can the day ever be felled
Where it turns to night, yet I remain sane?
Syllables find me pressed upon myself
Wearied by my own mental strain;
Tell me if the Fog is stalking me for all these years,
Obscured the fear lingering when I peered in the mirror

Sonnet of Melody

In my ears there rings a soothing melody
As if brought upon by my daydreams
Rooted in lost mind and forgotten memory
Reminding myself all is not as it seems;
And might I deem it sufficient in breath
To waste my words on lowly folk
Who cower from my brethren dressed
All in white and standing in fancy meadows;
Fatigue, again, is restless in my heart

And in memory joy departs, yet I see some
Whistling tunes penned by muses of the arts
I write now not for mere amusement but freedom;
Freedom from all that harms my mind,
Freedom I would sooner leave behind

Sonnet of Dissonance

I stride across more than mountains
Wander through no less than great monuments
There where I sing songs of praise and hymns
In the darkness of hallowed sentence;
I cannot help but feel sentimental
Though my heart is hollow throughout
Presently I hope for something trivial
Anything to break this silent bout;
And I reach to the clouds above
With arms outstretched I wonder
Had the lack of noise been woven with love
Would it have been as tragic as thunder?
Of things I have sought and things I now seek,
Dissonance wraps my mind and turns all things bleak

Sonnet of Calamity

In the sarcophagus of creation

Where confessions lie in snare
I laid to rest a conversation
And laid my sinning soul bare;
When innocent blood stained my steel
Guilt brought me to the brink of insanity
So I turned to the Lord with zeal
But I think, in his unfeeling eye, I was unseen;
So I covet death as the life-bringer
I call your eyes gray like starlight
On them my gaze lingered
When I know they are more like midnight;
In the deepest reaches of my heart, I felt you there,
When you left me defenseless against calamity's snare

just fancy prose

When innocent blood first stained
The silver of my sword, I struggled with strife
And guilt slowly turned me insane
But money saved my life;

But money worked to keep me sane
And soon when guilt waned, I ;

The pulsation of the
Only vigor can remain
Adrenaline courses through my
Think of things without merit
Think of things bittersweet
I've dreamt dreams too careless

Allege

Sonnet of Retrieval

I recall the day destiny drew forth
And laid a blade at my feet
I knew not what it was for
But I had a guess it was for me;
There, in the depths of night,
And, here, I should say
Is where I lost my sight
I say it was here I misplaced my way;
Down in dusk and clad in dust
I take to memory that day I won
The day everything seemed so grand
When that sword weighed but a pound and I was not shunned;
I cannot count my blessings on a single hand,

But I can the days since my sword has tasted man

Sonnet of the Trap

I, who have grappled with sadness,
Find solace in delusion
In places of frenzy and madness
I pray for absolution;
Now death is a dark destrier
Galloping in the nightly cold
Singing songs of dried tears
Telling me I am old;
He is Death, that dark destrier,
Whose ancient trap sees ages unfold
Having caged me untold years
As he gallops in the nightly cold;
Who claims I have woven his story from flesh into sin,
Into fabric again, the seams press upon my skin

Sonnet of the Damned

In living life to the fullest
I have accrued an earnest debt
And in taking from the wicked
I sought remedy for my head;
But no man could attain remedy

When all that is remedial
Had seen it just to combat me
Who wishes to be healed;
I ask can my past be waved?
So says the Damned man hither:
“No sin once sinned can be saved—
Yet I beg to differ;
Of a land Damned and trust-less,
What is life but cruelty and injustice?

Sonnet of Tranquility

In the halls of placid lakes
Where fantasy breeds reality
Imagination remakes the fake
And takes us on nascent journeys;
When falsity calls for pending removal
Sentimentality can be a virtue
And shall truth be deemed final
Judgment's gavel pays their dues;
I may say in the midst of superstition
Resting in that holy mission's care
That my soul craves a lengthy session
To abate this sorrowful Nightmare;
In this placid place that lacks disaster,

Can I say my days have never been happier?

Sonnet of Hunger

Shall hunger find me penniless

Stomach growling, never abating

I cannot hope to ever guess

The true weight of China plating;

Though I try to see in all the best

Walking past the street at hour late

So liberal a desire bars me rest

That nothing can truly sate;

Can I count on hated Fate?

Meat rare as rainbow hanging raw

I cannot count on fetid Fate

Dripping blood from my grinning maw;

Would they see me as something different,

If I bled blue blood and golden liquid?

(TenParlorTournament)Sonnet for Death

Forever cursed to outlast existence

I am the End of all living things

Strife-stricken with endless yearning

As I have been ever since;

We separated that night

When Fate made men to ponder,
She was my Life, bringer of light,
Who made you as my fodder;
Like lambs driven to the slaughter,
A cattle-driver, she drove you
Deep down into Death's dull-dyed waters
To bathe in an eternity of absolution;
Your absence is the thing, with lifeless, strife-stricken wings,
My judgment lapses without Life, my loving darling

Sonnet of Solemnity

Solemnity unbroken by annoyance
Is a thing I shudder to even wonder
In the tomb of the dead god's trance
Where the mother of stillness slumbers;
So I ponder on that solemn owl
While it sleeps, shrouded in oaky leaves,
Coated with black paint and a quiet cowl
On deep, night-wrenched eves;
Bred from placidity, an owl unburdened
By what wakes at night's emergence,
Breathing solemnity, serious and certain,
Unbothered by worldly disturbance;
Is it so, then, that the night has been weaved,

From the sitting, flitting fowl's solemn dreams?

Sonnet of the Cold

As the dreaded cold approaches

My soul and spirit dream of needed sleep

Casting summer to the side, winter encroaches

Swallowing me into the lightless deep;

Unable to weep one tear unfrozen,

I cry gently to myself, praying:

“Lord up above, holy-woven,

Tame this wintry spirit, make it lame;

Do thou here, at the first light of dawn,

As thou hath done forever long”

But you are deaf — Lord God, are you gone?

Why do you ignore me, my pain-stained song?

When, from on high, the first light of dawn breaks,

Find me in no other place, than its cold and icy embrace

Sonnet of Pondering

To set upon the idyllic innocence of youth

A burden no man should bear alone

You weigh his young soul with the truth

And give his dreams little room to roam;

Of a place not far from home,

Make him but a stationary
Carve his fate into his bone,
Let him never grow old and weary;
See him drafted into the military
And take upon the price on tour
Watch death see him ferried
And make him a victim of war;
There is a rumor, that dreams often part with their dreamers,
And every dream is severed like a fever

stressed for finals

am I?

idk but this poem is scribbled, scrawled, and miiiiiiiiiiiiiiii

Sonnet of Remembrance

Standing before me in silence,
Monuments of stalwart indifference
Zealous eyes drowning in dependence
Lingering with fake reverence;
I am made jealous by their presence
At what could have been my own
Caught in the ghost of repentance
My voice comes out in a hollow tone:

“Fiends and savages, statues in my tomb,
Monuments of a religious cure
Dependent on a virgin mother’s womb
You seek me! — I am salvation assured;
Yet I am no different, no less belligerent,
I am not your remedy, nor a medicine
Coated in clean Remembrance,
I am but a man — my head is sin;”
Watching me zealously, rows of statues in view,
Here I stand then, before the hallowed pews

Sonnet of Connection

What but dusk begins at dawn?
It rebounds in the early hours
But when the wick’s flame is gone
Light burns in dark’s shower;
What but light covets the early dark?
Except that praised with high acclaim
But of otherwise low remark
Tell me if these two can be the same?
But when the winds cease and die
And the land is mild throughout
See clear skies break to storm-eyes
And the rhythm of rain run out;

There is nothing in this world without its other part,
All is bound by some Connection, some quantum counterpart

Sonnet of the Sonnetless

I pity the dead poet
Whose words met death unheard
And the notebook he wrote in, forgotten
As his legacy is merged with the herd;
So now that he is lifeless
Dressed in Death and abolished
He is to be Sonnetless
All his Sonnets quietly demolished;
Shall I pity the old fool?
Who thought his work inadequate
Less a poet, more a fool,
At the mercy of his fearful wit;
Pity him, the poet sleeping lifeless,
Now honest in death, yet forever Sonnetless

Sonnet of Silence

Dear sky entombed in miserable gray
An assailant of the desolate shade
A player in your silent parade
You have swayed me with your ways;

For not indulging into you
I feel as though I am a fool
Succumbing to your cool abuse
And submitting to your soothing rule;
Having given me your silent pity
Sitting silently, clad in calamity,
Your gray eye is cruel and silencing
Seducing me independently;
Now bury me in Silence, so that I forever lie,
Silently entombed beneath overcast skies

Sonnet of Idiocy

I finally understand true idiocy
Through shared living with the imbecilic
It is neither vain, nor Folly,
But the immature pride of youth;
I learned this through his misery,
Though he would not call it so
He is ignorant to being brotherly
Every word I say is hollow;
I Persist, yet what is Persistence?
It is nothing before the prideful
Whose ears are above existence
And whose dreams are haughtily idle;

If divine pride is the grinning prince,
Then undeserved ego is the king of insolence

On this day, a vow was made.

Sonnet of the Exception

Born to a mortal womb
I am forever cursed with this mortal wound
Where impending loss forever looms
The tomb of time is accursed doom;
By accepting the unacceptable
I scoffed in the face of your pity
And rewrit the impossibility
Of death's inevitability;
Ever since my accursed birth
I have searched for power of the divine sort
Scouring the earth and all its dirt
In search of some immortal warmth;
A mortal who muted the immutable,
I am the Exception to the ineffable

Sonnet of the Rapture

Why do I not hear the sonorous chords?
Is justice deaf? Has silence befallen Death's church?

No! O would-be lords clawing at Death's door,
Slave-like masses, monsters craving Death's cure:
Know that I, alone, have seen the barren land of absence—
Whereby, practicing abstinence, his eminence will adore me!
And praise my Folly by entreating me entrance
To the realm of dead sentiment and silent pity;
So rupture my core in your Rapture — see it stretched, sore, and shattered,
Awash in weakness, but a mortal man — O savior of mine, weather this strife!
Age me in my thoughts—wrought my rot out from under me—
For I am laden in a certain misery—the misery of life;
Pardon my birth upon your breast, O deity of Death,
I would die at your request, concede my final breath

Sonnet of Darkness

I swim in the abyssal sea
Crawling among the lightless deep
Through the sea grove and coral reef
The Reaper's scythe hanging above me;
The menace of Darkness is meritless!
Yes, it is all Fantasia—feared, were it reality,
Yet, it is but the dreams of the dreamless—
Not my own! Bred of an incessant quality;
Still, I am unable to shake the thought—though I try—
Of the depth of my fearborn inadequacy

For it is death's determination to see me die
That has left my soul shattered inside;
O empty menace, my soul made lifeless,
Wholly at the mercy of my darling, Darkness

Sonnet of the Faultless

In a sense, nothing is so futile
As to find fault in the Faultless
In fulfillment of your own insecurities
Blaming the blameless relentlessly;
Nothing is to be shunned, then,
So much as it is to be undone
And bent to the wills of imbecilic men
Of who Folly finds no fault beneath the sun;
But Fortune shall devour! O the chance shall shine
And breathe life into despoiled lungs,
O wretched past and ruined future!
You gleam lusterlessly before my eyes;
By my borrowed sentence — say, crave you restless pestilence?
O present! That restless presence! Return to essence, and pay penance to the Faultless

Sonnet of the Sinner

If, in a man's haste, he finds
His hands nailed to a dying sign

What little life he lived defined
By the sins wrought upon his kind;
And of what he thought of death:
What little life lied in his eye
If ever dormant, he'd measure the breadth,
And proclaim himself the most significant;
As in the minds of the pious,
Morality is fallacy in immoral minds—
Caught by the grave and vanquished,
Hiding pity inside self-righteous eyes;
Serenity through sin redeemed sacrificially,
Is no less artificial than promised eternity

Sonnet of Circumstance

Wrought upon the world-stretched shore
The wretched sand craves me endlessly
And I find myself at such an impasse
As to warrant my drowning sanity;
Alone at the edge of the burning ocean,
I've learned to crave the placid sea
As in the fantastic dreams of fanatics
Shall my earthly captor set me free;
Yet I know such words betray my state
This Circumstance I find myself facing,

Although I hope—for tomorrow's sake—
That my ocean days are fading;
As the wild shore has forced my hand,
I stand and share my final plan

Sonnet of the Ancients

Oh love's chance to love another
And hold fast to them for dire comfort
There is nothing quite like romance
But the infinite pleasure of finite desire;
As in a liar, who knows little of love
To love another is purely of
Such a fail of face, a mistake,
One may say it is insane;
And still, I hurt against the past
When I look back and see my love
Watching me from the Heaven that stole her
I recall I am not so long from her as to hurt;
For I am no youth whose life is young,
But an aged man with an Ancient love

Sonnet of the Tangible

In the realm of the intangible
I seek some semblance of control,

That Death, in his mortal form,
Would form in me a soul;
But I know not my state:
Should I shiver in his grip,
Stranded in the dying cold
Beholden to nothingness;
There I grasp the unforgiving phantom!
And hold him fast, that he would not permit
Me some feeble recompense
For each hope he deemed unfit;
In a ghostly hope for some unlit wish,
I hope for nothing less than Tangible flesh

Sonnet of the Stars

The lonely expanse of space surrounds me,
Stars flickering faintly in the distance
Eternal, they yearn endlessly
For some semblance of redemption;
Breathless, helpless to their sentence,
I witness their struggle against the sky
And cannot help but shudder hence,
When light surrenders to darkness;
And so little is as radiant
As the sky that dies above me,

Rays burning at the height of day
Desperately searching for salvation;
In grieving silence, tears fill my somber eyes,
Watching dying Stars scorch the skyline

Sonnet of Sorrow

Naught is quite as incredulous
As the raspy grasp of death,
Its clawed hand reminiscent
Of Sorrows departed;
While inside I cry my life away,
And ask into the dying night
That if dawn be luminescent
Why, for all its holy light,
Does it not chase despondent dusk
From where that darkness hides?
If it be so incessantly appealing
To all manners of appetite
I ask, therefore, how the dying wind,
Can serve to please my thousand sins?

Sonnet of the Legion

The lesion of darkness is legionless
With its poisonous inheritance

Splendors wasted on martyrs,
Death married in resplendence;
Horrid hate is coveted
Like the second coming,
Christ is alive in death
Love is not so blessed;
Hypocrites, protestors
Marching on through bad weather
As though it is not venom
Seeping in through the silence;
The Legion storms the castle walls,
Their swords aimless as they fall

Sonnet of the Crow

In vain I have sought, not found,
Amid my search for penance,
Sought to hear a sound
Repeating with a cadence;
A song with a stark presence
Whose tone against the noise
Is an unmistakable cadence
Cawed out with great poise;
And the thought of a Crow
Perched in the lightless abbey

Watching from the silent row
At my movements, at me;
Dead is the deep night's fowl,
Starved of darkness and its cowl

Sonnet of Death

Restless is the grave of Death
When all that is unholy,
Wanders upon the accursed earth,
Dead and searching breathlessly;
Poisoned is its aching,
And so dreadful is the sound
Of a thousand fingers pulling
Reaching at the soil of the ground;
And so profane is the wound
From which sin, seeping through:
Into corpses, migrating—
A parasite of evil;
This act, which some have criminalized,
Is but a single symptom of suicide

Sonnet of Salvation

To keep a sanguine devil sane,
Fictional reality is its grace,

And truth is a damnable liar
Bleeding on the hunter's stake;
What worth are your pains?
Your life may yet be saved,
Or burned in the flames
Of forgotten Salvation;
Let burning hatred
Keep your earthly soul awake,
Away from temptation,
Free and untamed;
In every heaven minds have conjured,
Death is the only fear ever pondered

Sonnet of the Wind

The Wind howling in the silence:
From dying wails, turn to ice
Great idols fall to violence,
To the infinite excise;
Where quiet voices whisper low
Of haunted figures dancing fast
Inside halls of twisting bows,
Man's insanity outlasts;
There eyes are incensed,
Ears to their voices listen

Until they speak, their speech incessant,
Outpouring words of hated sentiment;
Where Wind has sent their lies defiant,
False oracles stand in silence

Tab 10

Pianist

These autumn-burned leaves
falling like
a heaving chest
and a question

For the one whose touch
I near not felt, who played
my favorite, whose
fingers plucked
Moonlight strings.

You—there, marbled
and parked amid wheat
with sawdust on your
wings.

You—ivory bust,
with copper crust
Harvard weather worn away;
cracked marble,
gold lines and specked
eyes

I move to touch

You fly away

and leave me staring
into the moonless night,
waiting

Soon, August

Heart that throbs
and trembling finger
at you—

Do not cry,
somber July.

Tears turn to vanity;
shed from eyes
that cannot see
but in distilled
memories.

Today Dies

Tomorrow will arrive
like a soldier returning
from days abroad;
tomorrow will arrive
even if
today dies.

In the entrance,
making contact—

With a pink
pocket knife,
you betray me,
to follow another.

If you would cast an eye
down to see this poor exhibit,
this sun-dried thing, scalped
beyond recognition
by regret and rejection,
aching.

And is patient
like a dog

waiting for his master
who ignores him.

Timing

'Tis a golden morning.

This wonderful sun,
this tree with singing birds,
the river with its fish,
splashing and playing,
and the predators
and the prey—
and then you,
without a smile.

“My forest burned down yesterday,” you say.

“This forest is kinder than the last.”

“But I am not over my forest,” you say.

“This forest forgives.”

“I would feel disgusting to use this forest,” you say.

“Then use this forest to grieve,” I say.

You walk
into the brush.

Tab 11

The Fall

Bated breath from out the frame
told the skeleton what good the idol wrought,
what craft the hand, and what nailed foot;
Torn from the sky, manmade chaos
came chasing after Heaven; the skeleton
withdrew, drawing limp,
and dipping down. All at once,
there came a great and ceaseless crowd
upon the holy sand, all crawling for
the fallen corpse affixed upon the cross.

The apocryphal eye of God looked down
on you, impudent mass,
you wretch, you heretic.

There is no cure for those exalted souls
who sicken near the burning firmament
and, drawing ever nearer to the fire,
drink deep the ichor, long to see the choir.

You, men of the aged hate, you sang
of endless wine and Babel towers,
but then the flood—no longer did you sing.

Then, your Icarus—his wing!

You withered, yet embraced
the insatiate vulture-beak to eat,
and drove your knees into the sand,
seven hands clawed
at the gaunt and scrawny chest—
three nails tore apart,
ten fingers in His flesh:
Thousands of pious men
eating of human bread.

Tab 12

Destiny

To every man is his natural destiny,
and to all a natural decline
from the face of predestination
to a fate sublime. So grave
is the suffering he endures
to maintain the natural hatred
of his natural course, and yet
so greater is his desire
to see his bodily likeness
maimed, then hoisted up,
on a crucifix of righteousness,
bleeding and barren.

Tab 13

Overwhelming Justice

So doth the rightful world turn
The abundance of my soul;
Held shut in a vise,
Locked tight there inside,
Liquifying as if it were ice.

Sometimes doth the world turn
over in its boiling gyre; and sing
to the symphonic heavens
a heathen's choir; yet if,
when all the world were silent,
men seek to be chaotic,
then so they are the tyrants
of a collapsing society;
Bruised and brutal beyond
the power of words to convey,
horrid in their vast sepulchers,
in broken disarray.

Here, in the deathly quiet,
so numerous are the victims
of past societies; behold me,

this sickened beast, kept locked

as feed for scavengers

and these rabid beasts;

Life is unworthy, yet

death is unimaginable.

How can we live here

where sound is silent,

where light goes to die—

Where vast and lifeless sculptures

watch us dance, alight?

Tab 14

Haikus From Boredom

Death departs the earth
Like a fleeting memory—
Symbols of regret.

Hatred among friends
A world enshrouded in flames—
What is burnt, is dead.

In lightless struggle
Is there any sanity?
Why do we still continue?

Frozen sky drips ash
On a land devoid of warmth—
Cold divides the land.

In icy numbness
A world succumbing to frost—
These wounds never heal.

Crimson blood flowing
A slave walks amid the war—

Steps trembling in the cold.

Pale skin succumbing

Emancipated rider—

Painful persistence.

Void swallows the sky

A world dark and fathomless—

A flickering light.

In this agony,

A soul once lost to darkness

Is found in the light.

In twisting darkness

Chaos pervades our senses—

Heaven descending.

Tab 15

Sickening Silence

There is not a man who stands
Against the world when it falls
But he whose hands are clean
Of the world's impure laws;
I am such a man!
But my lonesome hand refrains
From change to the global stage—
It knows its country's place;
Yet, solitary escape means death,
So to staunch the bleeding earth
Shall we not, distinct, converge
Into a single, unified force?
O ego! To you I am well accustomed,
Reason be damned.
Land held in the hands of man
Would rather rally hell,
Than bend beneath a banner
Offered by its predecessor;
It would rather face the end,
Hung from a common maw,
For even global intent cannot bend
The lion country's law;

In the name of all that binds,
I beg you, therefore, before me,
To hurry formality behind
And see the glory of man combined;
But pity, they say, is heresy:
Equality is the devil's wick—
And lo, this peace, this blasphemy!
Only fools raise their candlestick.
The silence that follows sickens me,
Man allies with his common enemy

Tab 16

Let My Death Outlast Me

Let my death outlast me
And impart my legacy
Upon the unceasing earth;
Let it sever the past me
In the act of rebirth—
From that spirit within, see
Whatever form it takes
And let it not be shaken
Nor find wrath incurred;
For that which forever dwells
Upon the unceasing earth
Knows my debt, its length and depth,
And yet, would allow my soul
The freedom to live again:
For though I face death,
I find comfort in knowing,
That my legacy survives
In the minds of those
Whom I so sadly leave behind;
Therefore, my son,
Allow me some tranquility,
And let me speak,

That my body not break
Before I can say this to thee:
Let my death outlast me,
Let it sever the past me
And impart my legacy
Upon my loving family;
And to every generation
That follows the first so fondly,
I entrust to them my lineage
And shall fear no longer
The grip of death's
Chilling indifference,
Knowing in this ending speech
I have spoken my final word
And taken my final breath

Tab 17

Be the Death of Me

Be the death of me,
Hurry my soul into the sky
Or thrust it beneath the earth
Into the searing pit of lava;
And so hold beneath the sea
The flesh that renders me mortal
And therefore fallible to destruction;
Feeling the waves render me insane
I begin to question whether I will remain
Until the sacred light of day
Illuminates all that is profaned—
Such is yet to be assessed;
And once, and only when
My sentence turns to punishment
I will reach above the waters
And fill my lungs with sulfuric air,
Then submerge beneath the magma
Letting myself be remade;
In the vise of molten slag
My eyes begin to liquify,
My body starts to smolder
And burns to black ash;

Salvation assaults my soul
And so here I wonder, waiting,
Thinking faintly of destruction
But more so its implication
That I need to live a certain way;
And I need not fear the fiery waves
Nor the pain which beggars cremation
Instead, as I look upon my past,
Upon all the actions I've enacted
And torn from families their fathers
Husbands from their wives:
I hope;
Tempered by the torturous sea,
I know in my heart,
There is no use in changing;
And so I resign myself to see
What lies for me beyond,
Since perhaps I may be saved
By some good god's grace
But suppositions can wait,
For I feel my end drawing close;
Nearer and nearer,
Looming beyond my sight,
Its impending horror terrifies me;

I tremble in fear,
Feeling each hair on my naked corpse
Stand to some perverse sense of attention
In preparation for the coming silence;
I feel him—and can feel upon my skin
The bated breath of death
As he plucks my soul from out my flesh;
From out my chest, his pace begins to quicken,
Hastening with the passing minute—

Nearing the end, I feel my soul slowly severed:
I feel my mortal soul begin to waver;
What strength I once wielded
Lava has rendered useless;
Each transgression layers atop the last
And my past consigns me to fate;
I will rest for eternity,
Here beneath the waves

Tab 18

O God

O God, can I know

How it feels, to grow old

And behold some young sapling

Whose roots are rough and bold;

Can I polish that stone

Turn his coal to emerald?

And curse the day that dawns

When he leaves me alone

Standing long at the broken house

That he leaves and takes flight and

Flies on his own?

When I covet his company,

Will he leave me behind?

O God, I cry, now he's gone!

Let time wear me down

And love heal my bonds.

Tab 19

Of Ash and Fire

I stumble through familiar streets, unable to make out the hazy features before me. Swathes of black ash coat the asphalt, leaving prints of my feet as I move past; like lost memories, soon swept away. Heavy soot swarms the sky and fills my lungs, forcing me to heave out heavy breaths every few moments.

Caught in one such sudden bout, I clench my chest as I fall to my knees, feeling a burning sensation welling up inside. My eyes widen in anticipation, and I seize my throat. Animalistic growls dwelling deep within me find themselves without the sufficient force to pry themselves free. The passage of time wanes, wavers, falls, and fails, slowing to crawl; and then, further, as the world's maw closes upon my agony, and time slows to a complete halt.

And then, in every fear of mine found out, explored, and exploited, and every finite desire of mine forever buried, the ugly face of pain rears its repulsive head, and burrows its claws deep within my solar plexus. I heave emptiness out my bleeding gut. I hear my own heart, beating within my chest. I whine. My whole body seizures and spasms in that moment, when time begins to walk once more. Clouds of black dust and burning ash, as if personifications of my hellish pain, pour from out my profaned mouth in violent coughs, returning to their home in the poisoned air.

Ill, I fall to my stomach, my eyes glazing over with pale despair. There is only despair in this rapidly descending darkness, for hope has long since been cured from my mind. And glad it is, I bare my teeth madly and groan harshly as I press my palms against the heated asphalt, raising my body from the soot.

I stagger to my feet in a daze, and wipe my mouth with a forearm. I can see nothing in this red haze, save that white, sovereign light at the end of the street. Hope, like desire, has long since left me. I am bereft of it! And yet, I should crawl so desperately for safety, as if it were the curse of humanity to desire survival to such a degree—of this race, I, therefore, press against the bounds of logic, and beyond.

Pulling my weary legs to attention, I force them forward for one last push. Agitated, the red-hot sun sears into my skin, boiling it, and leaving disgusting pustules in its wake.

I do not scream in pain; I do not even whimper. I am long past these easing mercies. Instead, I delegate every fiber of my being to this timeless struggle. Growing ignorant to my surroundings, I see before me only that one light, that saving grace, that infinite mercy, that heaven-sent forgiveness.

But I have no legs, no skin, no muscles—no sinews. My bodily form is bereft of autonomy. And yet I see my foot placed before the next, again, and again, and again. As if being controlled by another, I have lost all feelings of proprioception—perhaps it is a mercy, a

blessing. I breathe in the rank air. I smell nothing. It is a mercy, I confess, to be devoid of all feeling in a world of torturous pain. This ravenous hell, though its trials, has stolen from me my happiness, and in the same motion, my despair.

Reaching the end of the street, I come to an unbalanced halt. The light is before me, I realize. Motes of ash fall upon my pupil, agitating it—I do not blink. I almost forget to breathe, only when asphyxiation causes my gaze to blur and blacken—and I lose sight of the light—do I remember the motions.

I stumble forward, and am consumed by the burning light. Suddenly, I am awash in vigor, standing alone in a room of white walls and dirty, yellow light. Liquid life pours over me, revitalizing my body, and reviving my soul. I can think, I realize after a while, without the rhythm of pain playing in the background, as has plagued me for so long.

Curious, I look down at my ash-stained hands, only to find them smooth and peachy. Marveling at the sight, I clench them into two fists, feeling my sinews contract, and my muscles bulge, for the first time in months. An unconscious laugh, a dull chuckle, sounds from out my mouth, and I wonder if that clean tone came from me. I laugh again, this time on purpose. I hear it reverberate in the white room, and cannot believe my ears, but also cannot deny what I hear. I am laughing! Laughing! And so I laugh again, and again, and again, and again, until I am laughing at the top of my lungs, as if screaming. I laugh as loud as I can, laughing louder than the last laugh each time, as if competing with myself. And, as I do, my mind is totally blank.

I think nothing. I know nothing.

I am wholly insane. And I embrace my insanity.

Suddenly, the hidden cuckoo clock rings from inside the walls, and fear enslaves me. I wrap my hands around my chest, then look down to find them bound. I struggle, but the clock rings again, disorienting me. That alarm, that alarm, that horrible, horrible, four-armed alarm.

My subsequent laughs are caught in my throat. Usurping the throne of insanity, I shiver and throw my back against the padded wall. No! No! My eyes leap around the room, this terribly-cramped space, scanning for any sign... any horrible, hellish sign...

But I find none.

After a few minutes, I let out a shaky exhale, and blink in relief. As I open my eyes, I feel his arms wrap around me from behind, and his face bury itself into my back. I feel his mouth press against me, his lips moving in unheard words. And then I am pulled back into the abyss. I claw for the light, but am mercilessly swallowed into the hole in the white wall.

The scene changes three times as I fall, each a hazy blur, until I find myself somewhere familiar. Faced with cold reality, the endless cycle, I forget myself—no, I choose to forget myself—and am, again, imbued with that same curiosity.

In this place, I stumble through familiar streets, unable to make out the hazy features before me.

Suddenly, I stop. My mouth opens to speak. I can still feel it at this point. "More mechanic than flesh, more robot than human," I say, watching swathes of black ash coat the asphalt.

Emotion is dead sentiment before me, I confess, leaving prints of my feet as I move past.

Like lost memories, soon swept away, I am apathetic to my suffrage.

Tab 20

Riotous Insanity

Herald me eternally, as though I were worth more than my metallic shell,
More than molten steel, and more than myself,
As though time has made iron my legacy
And imbued it with bronze iniquity;
Or set upon it golden reverence,
Enacting my form in a marble bust,
An image unrestrained by any natural thing
But of such a sinister lust that my image is made insane.

And if it were, that the earth were to its core as it is to the sky,
Would its visage be as eerie as my own?
Could I look upon the scene clearly?
When the heaven rests above me,
And the ground pours out below
Should any man desire my death
And his life be made meaningless,
Sentenced to dead existence.

But if heaven made plausible my demands,
And let the earth succumb to itself
Would all its inhabitants, in their dying words,
Condemn me for my absurdity?

Or would they pardon me in my apology
Effectively forgiving my sentencing,
Granting me grace amid my iniquity,
And freeing me from my bondage?

O but I still want for things that I cannot have!
I afford nothing above me, yet would cry:
If any man would be so important in himself
To let fortune fall behind the rest?
To starve on his lonesome, beaten by cruel men,
His dignity shed, chained and enslaved—
To see him desperate, and walk by with a lowered head?

Of love, I will speak,
And be made no more than a martyr—
No less than a hero! In death, a lamenting prince,
Of everything cast before me, I shall admit,
Each I regarded infinitely;
And each, having been exhausted,
Has kept me here sitting silently,
My mind clad in riotous insanity.

Tab 21

The Taste of Heaven

I do not seek happiness in the heavens. They do not have that which I want. In fact, their mere existence burrows all desires of science in the hated occult, yet under the guise of beloved lords. Of all heavens, and their gods, each I am blessed to acknowledge, and just as tyrannical to turn away from—is what the zealous shall say. Indifference is my virtue. It always is, and always shall be. Still, I cannot simply watch as my purpose—of which I, alone, am master—is brought beyond my grasp by some unfathomable power. It is this very unfathomability, this universal iniquity, which bars my love. But He prescribes love, they will say, therefore I am meant to feel it. My consent is mandatory, regardless of my opinion. No, then, I will not. I refuse to lend my life as a pawn, to submit. For, in submitting, there arises an admittance of deep fear—and more, regret. It stems from the sought-after sciences, those the eye of church doctrine has, and always shall, look upon in derision and conceit. For these reasons, among more, I take offense to the title of “blesséd” and the absence of merit. So, too, for the same reasons, do I tarry at the gates of the heavens. You will see my shadow thrown upon the door there—then, and forevermore.

Tab 22

Thus Says Darkness

Pending my enslavement to His Majesty of the Raven,
I am still in soul, waiting patiently for entrance to his haven;
To that place years pass in torment, dusky and forlorn,
Where tears lie dormant, eerie blackness gives fear form,
Dull dusk is eternal, white moonlight immortal.

Thus says darkness, deepest friend,
As it consumes the vast gray land
And removes all waking thought from the minds of Man—
All is revealed under the light of the glowing sun;
As the waxing and waning moon sheds to bright-eyed dawn,
Who dares defile the placid statue of Alzalam?

Carved from pallid ivory, gleaming with silver starlight,
Stark in the darkness, contrasting ebony midnight,
Wretched fiends try with all their wretched might
To ruin the ivory statue of Alzalam, whose eyes are pools of absent light,
Whose Raven-wings, hidden from sight,
Are bearers of his darkened life,
Vigor brimming with ghostly light.

Unlike anything called weak, Alzalam is of a cloth, sole and unique;

Darkness precedes him, it concedes to him,
Attuned with darkness, he dives, spreading his wings—
A Raven immune to weakness, fluttering in the abyssal deep;
Whose Raven-wings, grim and gaunt,
Haunt the inflated dreams of the egotistic weak;
Whose Raven-wings, grim and gaunt,
Sing songs of what has been, in ancient shadow-fonts.

Then when wolves, to heaven, howl
In light's absence, he persists,
Blackened mist shrouds his form soundly
Eyes, in vain, search; yet he rests, unstressed, like this vowel;
Darkness is the perched Raven's dark cowl,
He is Alzalam, that ever-brooding fowl.

Tab 23

Apeiro

I was on the treadmill: I don't know how long I walked. But I didn't feel tired at all when I finally got off.

It was midnight then, I suppose. The machine slowly came to a stop. My feet were planted on the conveyor and my hair was matted with sweat. My hands gripped the machine's arms.

I stared at the wall, stared with that blank gaze. I didn't have questions nor concerns. Neither did the wall before me. It was a nice wall, a kind wall: it didn't judge. Maybe it did, actually. After all, it stood watch over me every single night, watching me recollect like this. But it had no will to voice these judgments — or perhaps it had no mouth — so I was content.

Some beeping suddenly sputtered from below, and I quietly realized it was the machine. The screen blinked and some numbers appeared. There were a lot of them, a long string of meaningless tones, each worth more to the next person than myself. I gave them a short glance, and dully powered off the machine. Darkness engulfed the room, the only source of light gone.

Fine in the dark, I walked to my bed and lay upon it, and stared at the black ceiling, all coated in nothing as it was — *made of nothing* I, at times, thought. What an existence that would be, that is, to not exist.

I had scarcely more than thought this when a faint clanking, as of some glass bottle falling, roused the ceiling from its nothing sleep. At that fallen tone, a voice remotely feminine whispered from above in such a sonorous voice it must have yelled: "This is the last time, Greg... The last! You're such a fucking piece of shit! I'm gone, Greg, I'm gone!" And I suppose that is when the glass bottle shattered into a million unrecoverable pieces; but the next morning those shards were always fixed back together again. She always came back. Always.

And every time she did — returning to his doorstep, entering inside, and seemingly making up with him for some innumerable-th time — the ceiling would shake rhythmically. I took no interest in my nothing ceiling then. I took no interest in anything then.

That was them, though, and I was me. What they did was not my problem — legally speaking. Morally, maybe. But at times these bouts angered me. I didn't rage nor crash into what little furniture there was in my apartment, but I certainly grew something more than annoyed. I was surely justified in this feeling, for I'm sure anyone would agree their heads looked better on pikes. Perhaps then they would finally shut the fuck up. I prayed to my nothing ceiling, which — on this particular night — seemed as infinite as the span of time that stretched from when I mounted the treadmill to when I was removed from it.

As the matter consumed my thoughts, so did sleep consume them; and soon I was snoring soundly in the night.

The moon paced outside, though its light never penetrated the blinds, for there were no blinds. I lived not on the ground floor, but below — and they did not know. Their minds were none the wiser. And so the moon's dull rays merely illuminated that no man's land which I dare not venture into. I dare not, for the last time I did no good thing came from it. I wake, eat, exercise, sleep. This is how it is. This is how it was; how it always has been, and how it always will be.

The early rustling of my formerly nothing ceiling betrayed that dawn had fallen outside, had bested night and awoken. My eyelids gently cracked and allowed the faint dim light that broke from some place — oh how I would like to know where! — to peer in at me and illuminate the room. I got out of bed, stretched, and sighed.

As was usual for morning, I opened the door and went upstairs. I moved cautiously when I reached the highest stair. Peering around the doorway to check if they had left the blinds down, I noticed that they had. No one was home, either. They both worked in the office. I think it was a long commute: they were never here in the morning. So I went to the refrigerator and set the door slightly ajar; the faint light emanated as of some treasure inside. I could smell my own hunger.

Yesterday, in particular, had been terribly unpleasant — he had stayed up watching the game and run out of beer. He was worst sober. I found no chance to acquire food then. So I made haste now, eating my fill.

Eggs, I ate those raw. Apples and carrots, I shoved down my throat. Beef, raw as when it was slain, with gore dripping down its tender portions, I ruthlessly tore into. My teeth gorged the food. I reached into a cabinet and procured a bottle of wine which I drank dropless. I licked my fingers, which had turned an odd mixture of purple and red, curtesy of blood and wine. I stopped for a moment. Would they notice the wine? If she returned first, wine would be her first lover; and his, vice-versa. They would notice the missing bottle. It wasn't cheap wine, either. He was more of a beer guy.

However, I can say without doubt that she would still accuse him of drinking it, regardless of whether he denies it or not; the truth is immaterial in fragmented relationships. I've learned that through audio alone.

I was safe.

Of course, I cleaned what I had dirtied, washed my hands, and threw out what I had used. Precautions were still necessary.

I was in the middle of washing a napkin I had used to mop up a spill when the front door opened wide. I didn't hear it: the faucet was running loudly. Light steps, two sets of them, poured in. It was her and another.

"Is that the faucet? God, the water bill! Can you go and turn it off for me, sweetie?"

The footsteps died and started out again. She had stayed behind for a moment. Her kid went ahead. I saw him first. He looked to me an illusion — for what was this? Who would be here now? Then I recalled the weight of his steps, the sound of those steps, and understood. He saw maybe a flutter of some quick, imperceptible thing as I dove over the counter and rolled away. I knocked the wine bottle — which I had yet to throw away — off the counter. I threw myself back against the wall, gaze wavering and totally frightened. I scrambled into the stairwell, then

tumbled down the stairs and flung myself into my room. The kid, carefree, waddled in moments after and turned off the faucet. She came in a little later, saw the glass shards of the broken wine bottle, and scolded the kid for having destroyed it. The kid denied the accusation. But kids lie. Kids lie. Frustrated, she relented and dropped the matter.

Back pressed against the door, I slid against it to the ground. I had never been so close to discovery, so close to death! They would kill me if they knew, kill me a million times over. I was better off here, in my little apartment. I paid! I paid through chores. I cleaned; swept, at times. I had earned my little apartment. What right had they to steal it?

Oh, God...again, again! The treadmill! The treadmill!

I was running before I realized. Running, wheezing; but my heart never reached the pace it had earlier. It never beat so hard, but it beat to the pace of the running rubber that slipped back beneath my feet. Back, and around again. I cannot say when first I regained consciousness, though I can say that it has been far from the ruined mood that wracked me before. I thanked the treadmill with my silent steps for robbing me of despair.

It has been a while now, I think. I should stop; I shouldn't tire myself. But I didn't stop, and kept running. Not harder, just something between a light jog and a starting run: the sort of pace that sobered me, that robbed me off my constant delirium — the sort of uneven rhythm that kept me lucid.

Tab 24

Someone I Quite Liked

In a world where everyone's fake

Today I met someone real

He is constantly made fun of

At times for fair reason

But I've never seen him stoop once

And apologize for his actions

So when he graduates,

I'd like to give him my congratulations

For he is the best of us

Born with the worst mindset

And nurtured unkindly

By his school's temperature

Dear H, all praise in your endeavors!

I hope you only greatness in the future

This I curse you, no malice whatsoever—

For the truly great need no blessing

They need no tears whatsoever

Only desire between him and victory

Strive and all shall be claimed

All you need is strive

Oh, God! All you need is strive

Strive, for I knew you a day

Yet I see the cloth we are cut from

Dear W, seize the sun!

Tab 25

On Time

Time is a mistress, she sows seeds of growth in my fertile heart. When I wake tomorrow, I can rise knowing a new sun has similarly arisen. It is all her doing; she is not so bad as some claim. Really her passage only marks change, and is change not what we all seek? Even those stagnant are only stagnant until death. Time is an engine fueled by nothing. It works on oneself as it does on all, yet I think time has blessed me more than the rest. For I wonder, at times, whether change is what I seek or whether if, in changing, my days will turn bleak. But I have never wondered whether Time is a friend of mine; no, line by line, I never grow meek, nor shall I ever embark with fear.

Tab 26

We are all the same

We are all the same

If not in name then in shared days

In blood that bleeds blue

In eyes of similar hue

And yet our greatest adversary is not rust

But the ones we should drink with and trust

We argue of politics and social cues

We kill our martyrs and shun our heroes

Where the loudest is so often not true

We bolt ourselves to opinions and deem others untrue

Thought is not expression unless it's shared

Art is art till it's called unfair

We are what remains of the past and that is dust

The past — where History remains untouched

Where the marks upon our bones bear no rust

Where our lies spread like wildfire

And our days went by hushed

In the common age of today

What we often look past, refusing to realize

Is that our differences are the truest stake
In the hope for society to unify
And fight for a common sake
Ever contrary — for we are not all the same

And so like this we must
Must — as we have risen from that earthen dust
Together, in a bond unbroken by Time's evil rust
And its whispered secrets which seek internal betrayal of us:
Mend our cracked state — repair it with wood,
Rewrite the prejudice, diminish the negative
Annul ifs and past pretenses, sowing seeds for a common good —
Break open a can of brotherhood and drink to our differences

Tab 27

Haiku

Beautiful leaves

Vibrant, so crimson and green

But what of the trees?

So is light's trade all

In infinity's cradle

It saw where dark falls

What such sensation

Gives way to salutation

Undo of nations

Tread carefully you

Enemy! Master sent thee?

Then do rest easy

I permit, fellow

Though your leaves carry yellow

Entrance to my hall

Embellish shellfish

Take a risk, then fish a wish

When true, list a twist

Delicate, fragile

Swift, like a windswept trial

Nimble and agile

Tab 28

If Only

If only,

If only I had been born sooner.

But this is just a rumor,

Flaying my mind;

Quite possibly a tumor.

Fine!

I knew naught of history;

Still!

Anything would trump this misery.

Thus it was in the evening while I wasted

That she came to me quite late.

In a dress of flowing white

Surely it must have been Fate.

More than bright; indeed,

She was quite the sight.

I watched her figure

As her fluttering garb flowed;

She was Day's veil
And Night's cloak.

But just as sudden
Time slowed;
All froze.

The room warbled and spun.
She took me by my sleeve,
And through a wormhole was I wrung.

Through time did my soul affix,
Trailing this woman whom I knew only mist.

And past the skies did we soar;
Over valleys did we leap!
Till finally,
Finally we came upon what rested atop the peak.

It was the dawn of the world.
Here where dinosaurs roamed,
No longer fossilized bone
Clad in scales in this prehistoric zone.

Vividly, the great tyrannosaurus,

Who stomped the lands.

The gargantuan leviathans,

Who flooded the sands.

But the woman in white did not wait,

And quickly did she take

Dragging me up and past this

Prehistoric Dream.

We flew once more.

And my soul did it careen.

Till again was I wrung

In another era

This one of frost

And in my head was time lost

I came to in a land of ice

And in her eyes rested a question

But still I answered:

"No dice."

Again we flew.

As time warbled,

As we fluttered through.

Firmly I remained gripped to her

Placing my life in her embrace.

I trusted her,

Though I had seen only a sliver of face.

And no sooner did we approach the next place.

We landed among rubble,

In a garden of insurmountable trouble.

Under a king of Sumerian rule,

Babylon, did we view.

And off again just as soon,

To the next Sumerian legend,

The City of Akkad

We did siege through.

Of wide seas,

He was the lord;

Great oceans did he ford,

But in spotting us as we soared,

He brandished his sword.

And if I might be bleat,
For a man of little name in fate
Little fame in face
And feats without date
He was exceptionally high on his Sumerian seat.

The first king of history
Sargon the Great;
Though his reign is shrouded in mystery
Our arrival shouldn't be too late.

She and I stayed not a moment longer
For seconds sooner our heads should have fallen
At the feet of this warmonger,
Who charged our disappearing figures with reckless abandon.

Luckily, the rift absorbed us
And we flew through as if a race
Quickly to the next event
As sweat beaded down my face.

With all this spatial drift
It was near impossible to stay sane
But soon my spirits would lift

Till then I can only feign.

We warbled once more
And were spat suddenly
Upon the shore.

Disoriented,
I looked up from my trance
And before me glittered
A vast expanse.

The Aegean Sea.
I was entranced.

This was the first location
I felt truly free.
Here, by the Aegean Sea.

Across the blue
Its wings shot out
As early Greece
Sprouted round.

But then did I see

An army by the sea;
A legion of golden abs.
In tow a horse,
The size of a house.

They saw me not
And thank the woman in white for that
But still I wondered:
"What era was it
In that a horse that fat
Was naught but flab?"

Surely, there was something
Sneaking behind those slabs.
Voices whispering,
Drowned by the sound of marching abs.

Then I knew,
This one was too soon.

Alas,
Like the eras before
It too was
Unfit and sore.

Thus,
As before,
Indeed, to her I did implore,
That we forsake the Aegean Sea,
And continue our journey
Through Earth's lore.

Again we were sucked
And again we were spat.

When I wrestled the stun of swapping time,
Finally did I see
In a mixture of recognition and jubilee
The sight of dreams.

Still only a century later,
Yet the lands had grown prosperous.
Ere the time of Socrates
Still there managed the essential monolith.

Truly,
A pillar of modern society,
This quickly growing city

Yes!

The Eternal City.

Rome.

The home of Earth's longest empire.

In this place of dreams,

Truly,

Everywhere I might gleam

Every sight I might savor

Was mainly full of menial labor.

Still I looked further:

I saw the science

And the culture;

I saw the architecture,

I saw the people.

Many in number were they,

Full of cheer

As they mumbled legends

The brothers Romulus and Remus

And the empire their lives did build.

But still,
I am left to think;
Because still
I stood paralyzed,
My ambitions unable to blink.

This Eternal City,
In having everything,
Still lacked the thing for me.

Truly,
What a pity.

Downtrodden,
I wallowed.

Misery was all I could expect.
I swallowed.

And the void in my heart,
Felt a a little less hollow.
For her hand was there,
On my shoulder,
She did care.

That woman clad in white
With skin more than fair.

Then,
Whisked away once more,
Centuries floated by,
And again did we soar.

Space tangled before me
And time, it did leap.
Soon my eyes reopened,
Her efforts would I reap.

I sighed at the sight
For still did we linger
In the City Eternal;
Still, behold my stupor.

For the skies did I dread then,
As red paint was flung
And ash, rock, and gray
Seized my vision
While smoke filled my lungs.

The eruption of Mount Vesuvius,
That feeling of impending doom
Truly it was the same
As witnessing nuclear fission.

But the mushroom would not touch me,
For as soon as the waves of smoke hit,
A hand latched round my wrist,
And through a wormhole was I wrung.

Only sooner than I could cough a storm
Did we stop
And before me did I witness
A thing forlorn
The Bible's greatest event,
At the sight did I stop.

Before me,
He was stabbed into a cross.
But unlike most
His soul was not yet lost.

In a field of crosses

Was his body tossed.

In a field of crosses

Did his thorny crown rest.

In a field of crosses

Did his limp head hang

At the peoples' behest.

But I could bear the sight no longer,

So quickly as I beckoned,

Did we leave for the next location.

Indeed did we sift

Through a storm once more.

And only a millennia later

Did we finally burst out the wormhole.

My knees clashed with stone;

And twelve swords unsheathed

Prepared to cut me to bone.

But then a hand did raise

A presence which set my heart ablaze

A vigor the likes only

Merlin's chosen could attain.

The swords did re-sheath
Still, the knights were seething with fury
For only in their king's presence
Were they forced to show mercy.

I looked up;
But to my surprise,
The presence which spared me
Belonged not to prodigal fate
Twas not legendary King Arthur
But Charlemagne the Great.

The Holy Roman Emperor
And king of the Franks.

A man of visual appeal
And kingly, regal;
Near him did I feel meek
In the knees, weak.

I scrambled away
Back into the wormhole
My heart set ablaze;

As the wormhole began to fade
A thing nearly robbed me of my gaze
Twas a bolting sword of silver
Aiming for my face.

Scared,
I closed my eyes
And luckily it vanished
Without a trace.

Again through a wormhole was I wrung
Till finally I was spat out
Under the whirring sun.

In my appearing
Did I witness
A wave of light
Washing over the horizon.
The clashing of white steel
Ripping apart ligaments.

Seething, their suits gleamed
Their faith, ripe like wine

And so did their bucket helms shine

Crosses,

With their hands did they sign.

But as I stood there amidst

A battlefield heavensent,

I simply could not fathom

The point of the event.

As much as the cold night leaked

Was as much as I wished to sleep

The tidings of this time were far too wild;

I simply could not find it in me to smile.

Disinterested and disappointed

The wormhole opened for me again,

And through it I leapt

And through it was I sent.

Again time whirled to life

Carrying me through its expanse

What next would be my plight?

As time cleared for me to see

I found myself in a place serene

A place of peace

During the time of reformation

In the land of Florence, Italy.

Where Humanism was slowly becoming less moot

And the times were following suit.

I stood almost astral

Behind a man lit by oil lamp

Peering over his shoulder,

I bore witness to his plans.

As he penned a comedy

Of the divine sort.

But upon closer focus

In it did I notice

The theme mortis

And what happened post this.

Atop the papyrus

Signed Italian-stylish

The man who penned his deepest wish

Dante Alighieri

Author and political activist.

Watching his pen trace letters across the page

I felt a tad sentimental

And I thought back to prior days,

Was I truly as unhappy as I claimed?

As I thought these thoughts,

Dante turned the page

And looked over his shoulder

Just as I was whisked away.

He looked to where

I had seconds ago been

And uttered the phrase:

“Must have been the wind.”

In the wormhole I flew

The currents threw,

And at another point in history

I drew.

My eyes gleamed at the sight

Of a crow or a raven,
A man clad in black;
He looked to me
And quickly I began to act.

Over a bleeding corpse he rose
And at me he groaned.
But in all my fright and antirepose
I backed away nearly too slow.

Immediately,
The woman clad in white
Dragged me back through quickly;
Her eyes held the words of apology.

But the moment was fleeting
And luckily the Bubonic Plague had not seeped in.

Thus again was I wrung
Through a wormhole
And flung at the sun.

But I did not scare
As the wind flowed through my hair

As I was bound for the ground
I felt her gales soften the air.

Carefully,
I landed upon the Orleans fortress
And bore witness
To that young lady's courage.

Entranced,
I stayed
And soon did I see her flayed
Burned at the stake.

But at least in death
Was her name inscribed
In the tomes of the church
For which all might hark:
The saint,
Jeanne d'Arc.

Again I walked away
And through a wormhole was I wrung.

I exited just as fast

And beheld the great blue
From atop a sturdy mast.

Land ahoy
For before me, untrodden views
Suppose except for the natives
For they were here long before.

But could they win
In a war?
Because if not
Then the land was as good as ours.

And so we stepped upon the grass
Leading ourselves further past.
Columbus led the pack
And as he did, I stepped back.

Thus again was I wrung
Through a wormhole
Was I flung.

I landed in a bed of cotton;
The air smelled of nothing

My curiosity soared

And I began to suspect something.

Where had I fallen?

Or when,

I suppose.

But then when I saw

That the sheets were not made

Suddenly did I realize

That it was in my own bed that I laid.

But of absolute surprise to me

Out of all locations I had visited

Along my travels

Across the history of the human race;

It was only here

In my place

That I felt at peace,

In my bed

In the modern day.

If only,

If only I had been born sooner.

But this is just a rumor,

Flaying my mind;

Definitely, O definitely

A tumor.

Tab 29

{Never-End}The Dainty Faerie

At the outskirts of the world

The farthest corner, unkempt

A place all nocturnal

A place called Never-End

The Outskirts of the world

At its very end;

The farthest corner told,

Nocturnal and unkempt.

Where drunkards mumble

Drivel of the realms,

Bards who dare travel

Number only in the tens.

To this place

So far beyond mend.

To the domineering vista

Of Never-End.

The metallic stench of rot

Hangs in the air

Nowhere to vent,
And only fools say it's not
A welcoming scent.

Here, knowledge is a keepsake,
A mistake
A remedy all faked,
All jaded in the economic lake.

If only it were theirs!
That splendid knowledge!
These thoughts almighty,
This thinking sightly.

Why, what preposterous drive!

Knowledge?
The great equalizer?
That binding bridge?

They would never allow it
Not even a lick.
They would never give the chance
No! Not a single glance.

No, not for them,

No, not for them.

For the gem'd!

Those owning heaps of gold,

And those silvery holds,

Perpetuating the ever-unequal societal mold.

In their tipsy satin robes:

Devilish violets

Purples and blues;

These are the gem'd,

And they control the clues.

Feasting on thee,

The woes of thee;

Privileges of the highest order,

All for them:

Hoarders! Hoarders!

But this no more;

No, thee shan't concur

No, thee shan't agree

For this done to thee.

And tis revealed

As the sun slides back

For all to see;

As day fades to black,

And gold meets steel.

Claim now that

Which belongs to thee;

Of riches begotten,

Stolen from thee.

Now go forth upon the castle:

Charge the throne

Raid the palace

And carve them to bone.

Let bloodlust reign;

Stain that steel!

Be their bane,

Make them kneel.

At once!

Grind them to dust

Make their skulls bust

Thee must, O thee must.

Then while the horizon is ivory,

Ebony moon descent;

Mortar is strewn across the foothill

Aimed at each satin windowsill

On this lunar event.

The iron spasms, spasms and rolls

And crashes Cyclopean stone,

Defiling it to the bone;

A smashing heap

Of smoke and debris.

Their shrieks are endless

So haughty up there,

In places once so fair,

So full of riches and boundless fares.

But now they sleep,

Among mortar

In the deep;

Their souls so they weep,
Dribbling down,
That crimson as it seeps
Sinking by each
Wretched
Grand piano key.

Soaring o'er
Lands reborn,
Hands unshackled,
O'er radiance once adjourned.

Ere then a dainty Faerie,
Wading through the deep.
Woken by the myriad
Of mans' many triumphs and leaps.

He is the messenger,
The dainty sort;
Though existing only in myths,
His image shan't distort.

For up there amidst
The ebony-ivory conclude,

Flutters that sneaky minx of a Faerie,
Far away from the crass and crude.

[[That Faerie whom You are drawn to.
That Faerie whose arms You are falling into.]]

And when his little teeth poke out
Like a foxy treat;
You meet his shimmering smiles,
From your Cyclopean seat.

As if hymning the same tune,
Those dainty little smiles,
Aimed right at You.

Each and every one of them,
Aimed right at You.

Tab 30

{Never-End} On A Fiery Lake

Stranded in dire straits,
Where I claw at first ray
Seeking order in the day;
Finding only destruction in its wake.

The bane of all men
Hither in Never-End;
Clung to a strand of silver,
He withers.

And I watch from my mount
At the three-headed hound that caws every sound;
That beats the drum of spontaneity,
And summons the lashing of Hades.

Hither in Never-End
Where the earth quakes,
Violently,
As the world shakes.

O Hatefully,
For their sakes.

As my heart aches,
Stranded in dire straits;
Clawing at first ray,
In a sea, in a lake
Of fiery make.

Tab 31

Executioner

Premature sunlight,

A swarm of giggles roaring,

Laughing, sighing.

One...

One is dying!

As axehead replaces the starting sun,

Time is reluctant,

It... comes undone.

Resolve gushes forth,

Soul squeals,

Crowds full of zeal.

But why?

Why?

Why...?

Who wronged them so?

Was it him? He who fell prey?

He, the only in dismay?

A glint of light catches the reddened steel

Axehead falls

Like twisting timber.

Feel, feel.

Splash — a head joins the gore.

Its blaming eyes rest on me.

Before, before.

Sometimes...

Some... times...

Seeing the bleeding head roll,

All guilty after the blood toll,

I grasp at my neck,

Kept on my shoulders

by a single string of glue.

Shifting,

Shuddering,

Muttering:

“What if mine did, too?”

Tab 32

Cthulhu

Solemn moonlight,
Flickering torch high above,
Sand crunching beneath my feet.

The waves crash and break
against the beach
Pooling, heating my toes an icy cold.

My flame's last breath,
a gale takes it,
Smoldering out in darkness.

Only darkness.

The moon is gone
And in its place there lay,
A tentacled-face.

[Thank you, Chef, for your instruction.]

Tab 33

Betwixt the Twilight Moon

Betwixt the Twilight Moon,
The sun careened into view.

Trenches everywhere.

Sleeves pulled,
Hands rubbed,
Festering potholes,
It was all so numb.

But everything was so green.
Everything was so serene.

Plains of mildew,
Grassy sinews,
Tied beneath my feet.
Rustling, brustling,
Beneath my feet.

I laid to rest my dirty shovel
Beside my humble town abode.
And set to work a boiling kettle,

A calming tea,
Jasmine green,
But it was so cold.

Stooping beneath the dark,
As the fire played with my peeling skin,
My pale fingers etched thin:

Sincerely, writ I,
Tracing my meandering touch across the page,
Ink-crossed marks,
Scribbled shapes.

Here, beneath the light,
The careening sun,
Shoulders hung,
Betwixt the Twilight Moon,
Back hunched.

Buried in soft embrace,
Thou hath no case!

Lament,
Placid shovel, lament.

Never will your handle withstand me,

Coffers of steel.

Kneel!

There, where the safe lies,

In the last room, the lowest floor,

The narrowest corridor.

O lamenting shovel,

To open its tight embrace,

Need you, a cellar key.

This is simply,

The with-thought melody:

A Gravedigger's Remedy.

garbage uhhuhhhhh

Tab 34

A Bardic Man

I am no more a bardic man, no more a poet,
Than the abolished bristles of a beard,
Rufling silently upon an inquisitor's blasphemous shears.
There is no sound but me.

And strum!
My hands numb at lyre's embrace,
Plucking oh so readily
At brightly-glowing silvery strings.

Striking these songful wires,
Chords a melancholic blue,
My eyes fill with boundless tune,
And my fingers sing, too.

The tavern glows with boundless life,
A light amidst the bumbling knives,
Where washed away are those feelings that incite strife,
They look at me not with their eyes, not with their ears.

Rest, my song reaches them gently,
Playing along upon the strings of their hearts with synchronizing cues.

Caressing their emotions, their moods,
With vibrancy, the radiant tune exhales song and dance.

While they chatter,
Ale-drunken tankards rising and sighing,
My heart throbs with blissful joy—
As I were an inventor, presenting a new toy.

And in doing would receive a load of candid cheers.
So, graciously, my heart would not quell to that feeling persuading,
Carelessly craving, just heartfelt, Heaven-sent,
Tastefully, like a sweet slice of soft brie.

Tab 35

Cycle of Life and Death

On the avenue where dreams go to die,

Silhouettes aimlessly wander,

Meandering on a lonely night.

When there is present such a bustling,

A rustling, upon that alleyway street,

Then Man shall faithfully ponder.

O God, why must acts of this nature go unpunished?

For blowing harshly was the wind,

Whistling up and down that grimy alleyway street;

Drenched in the reek of pain: a dulled, gray misery.

Is it but in death alone that we face judgment?

How unfair it is that my bones ache,

Splintering like infinite hail—

Raked to the side and tossed away,

As if upon a silvery ideal,

I was but a prisoner of the Worthless jail.

Under divine grace, the earth is rung,

In the soil, a grave shaped.

And within that grave, un-cremated, there lies a boy —

A boy of merely eight.

Juvenile though he was, on the day the Reaper stole him,

Sailing away to the far-off lands above;

Where sadness chased him,

And atrocity bathed him.

Hate is a word quite fond to Man's vocabulary, barking it since the times of yore.

Nearly this, and nothing more.

No, nothing more.

Tab 36

Seeping through a Shadow

My eyes grow dull gazing upon you.

My muscles sting with feigned clearness.

My limbs wrestle the unrelenting assault of sleep.

I sightlessly see, hurt, distraught.

I writhe in cold blood,

Trickling down my spine amidst the red of my beating veins.

The Sound of Silence freezes the air,

And all is still, maimed in icy despair.

Journeying through the night, restless I stirred.

Eyes drooping, rag-dolled upon the floor.

Legs spread before me in a sort of feared play,

Hear me now, when I say:

That upon that hearse,

My name seldom be carved, even called. Never cursed.

With cloudy drags, puffs of blue snow from my snare,

This matter shall be forgotten in the annals of a most fetishized tomb.

Reaping despair.

As most things are, forever rare.

Mouth agape, voice swirling with turmoil, my words tossed into the night's eye,
"Menace!" shrieked I, fearfully, "Reveal yourself unto me!"
Reap your despair!

There was no sound, save the croaking of an ominous toad,
And a band of crickets, playing betwixt me and the nightly crows.
My hands, trembling, brought the sheet before my teeth.
Drooped in white cover, I found myself waiting silently, very stillly.
Heart beating ever so fervently — so loud! so very, very loud!
But ever so sonorous in my ears, thus I could think of none else,
Of no sounds.

Merely perverse waves of paranoia,
Falsified, perchance; yes, this could be it—
But I wouldn't believe it, for above all else,
When it came to my senses,
There was only faith.
Even before you, a shadow-wrenched Wraith.

Perched upon your withering flame,
Eyes snapping me from someplace,
Lacking all sense of shame.

My bones would snap,
My skin would peel;
When suddenly, my flesh begins to heal,
My blood congeals, and the Wraith reels.

The nexus of my heart burns with flame which mends,
The desire to bend, to rend
The impetus which spelled my end.

Should the dripping curtain to my bleeding heart fall,
I'd drown my sorrows till the morrow in a land so raw.
I have no hopes — no, nothing at all.
Despair, in my eyes, is the treacherous dragon's maw.

Flame's embrace is such a cold thing.
But as daunting as it may seem,
It's what I wish for—
A smiling dream.

A fleeting thing—
I see it in the scattered light
Escaping from the hall, into my room
Through the door ajar, taking flight.

Blackest shadow slithering, stretching from afar.
So very tall, with eyes emitting such a dusky song.
Clad in black as you slip through the crack,
Mouth drooling, your violating gaze pierces into my back.

A collage of the most matted flesh,
Mangled, tangled — abysmal and grotesque.
Despair raging unchecked, I pale-face and brace
As the ship begins to wretch.

With rum and with gin,
Filled up to the brim
Is the ship that ferries me across the lake,
Molded of wicker.
So thin.

I would never be so dull, as to scuttle that ship's hull—
For then the silver of your snickering blade would flicker;
And heads would roll.

What a disgrace.
Before you, but a thrall;
Suppose I should learn my place
In the throes of Bhaal.

I know you're there, lurking in the shadows;
I know you're there, laughing soundlessly in the darkest corner,
While bedside, restless, rests I, fearfully cowering.
Dreadfully souring.

Skin crawling with rapturous tempt;
Oh, how egregiously you must laugh!
Erupting terribly to your lonesome self with sheets of giggles, warm and wild.
Watching me — watching as my figure stirs like a frightened child.

As embers of spotted light crackle, fluttering upon the sill,
My shadow prances upon the wall, like an idiot, never still.
My voice crackles like a dying flame,
And by now, I am forced to wonder silently:

Ponder violently, have you simply left?
Vanishing without a trace?

Or wonder, in that moment, that very moment,
Wrapped up in Darkness' tight embrace:
For only then did I learn — learn enough to know when I'm mistaken,
Shuddering as I cried, "Present yourself — your case, foulest Forsaken!"

O God, what a blissful sight!

Or not, for here, there is no light.

Muffled shrieks in this place of blight,

You, that Wraith — but a shadow in the night.

Just look!

Your streaky glances and your ruffled figure!

Your paint drips down.

Dripping down,

Pitter, pitter.

Oh, how with twilight-colored despair you stain my soul a pale shade,

And provoke my burrowing within the sanctuary of piled white sheets till the break of day.

Hatefully for that, among more, I say unto you now with voice ever so shaky:

"Wretch! you grandstanding, tricking sheet of light!

This is what you sought from the beginning, ill-mannered fiend—"

—Or is it not, as I deem?

Tab 37

Paradise

High — high, high up! — a cloud of misty white floats across the gleaming ocean. It paints a visage of a grand ship performing a voyage just as grand beneath the warm sun's glow. Fluffy and pristine, an untouched relic, the lonesome cloud sleeps soundly up there on its perch.

Up, higher, on the back of this cloud, some patch of greenery claims the spot. In the middle, full of radiant sparkling, a small spring sits calmly. On its banks there is no trampled grass, no flowers dug up by their roots; no mismatched terrain, neither are its proportions too great, too small, but rather perfect in size. Truly, this spring was the epitome of beautiful, even more so with the aid of the orange-colored sun, under which it shone a nice, hazy gold.

Small trees, all nearly the same size, hung not above the spring, but a small bit from its edges. They dared not encroach on water's edge, not even allowing their venomous shadows to lean upon its golden grace. Merely existing in the water's presence was enough for them. Their leaves were of a dull green, and not a single ounce of life coursed through their thick plant fibers. From a ways away, one would be hard pressed to call this image alive, yet it was not without the vibrancy of life. If anything, it seemed a dichotomy between the two. This place, it existed within a league of its own.

And what is that if not the essence of paradise?

As the cloud drifted further over, approaching a new continent, a small yellow light glinted upon the water's surface. Yellow-white light, a splendidly royal color, exuded from the small thing resting upon the water, napping quietly. With light steps it woke, rose into the air, the flapping of its silken wings so tender, so soft. It spun and circled the island-cloud in mesmerizing arcs, as if it were a happy lark.

This being was none other than the mythical elf of legend, known only to Man by nigh forgotten lore from the times of yore, the only being of appropriate standing to reside upon this paradisiacal island. Fluttering upon the tiniest of gales, drifting from water's edge to water's edge, sinking beneath the cool surface and lying in the short grass — were all indulgences of this little elf. Above its illustrious skin sat a yellow cone of coalescing hair strands, bright as can

be. And beneath that, a pair of eyes tinted a golden-yellow. It had a small button nose and long ears that lifted skyward, though unable to reach for any sort of paradise or heaven, as it already knew the most bountiful of them, the most beautiful and exquisite. Alas, the most frugal, too. There were no decadent halls, no purple linens nor gold galore. No haughty nobles, no snarky mistresses, and no shameless actings, as many places in this world dubbed “paradise” might require. Though many of these are those built and inhabited by Man, and Man is not known for being a peaceful society. The opposite, matter of fact. No, this paradise was merely a spring and nothing more.

Yet that is precisely it! Precisely the reason for its outstanding beauty, a radiancy the elf might bask in. The frugality of its existence, simply such a worrisome place, free of so many attachments, allowing it the light of humility and freedom. Of relaxation. Of peace.

By virtue, paradise was the escape from all chaos. And thus, the elf, on its journey continent-to-continent, found itself pondering largely on the feast surrounding it. As an elf, it need not worry about hunger, a boon of its race, and so this feast was solely spiritual, maybe even a bit philosophical. Flapping solemnly above the still waters, it would rack its brain thoughtfully, pondering, pondering slowly. Ever so slowly. So carefully, with much anticipation ringing in its bird-sized bones.

Despite being on its lonesome, it did not fret, rather such a thing allowed for a calmer collection of his thoughts. Though, to be honest, it would not have minded a companion. Conversation once a decade or so would have given it some joy. Then again, even spaced a ten year apart, this would still allow for many conversations, as elves had lifespans far longer than those of humans and other races.

Years would pass in the blink of an eye, yet the island-cloud remained mostly unchanging. Much like the elf on its surface, still pondering, pondering ever so slowly and carefully. However, it soon passed above a narrow continent, and charged into the Dark Lands. How wretched a place it was, filled with ghouls, ogres, goblins, and other menaces. The elf looked down from its perch with a narrow gaze, and sat along the edge of the island. It began to observe the proceedings below keenly. It had no need to leave the cloud and fly below to watch, something that could possibly spell its end, since elves, betraying their miniature size, had eyes that could pierce the farthest distances. Even up beside the fellow clouds, on its small, paradisiacal spring island, was it able to see down to the ground, nearly as if it was but a meter away and not thousands above.

And soon, dastardly things of dark came into view, ranging from boiling red skin to tongues of dreadful lengths, the creatures below were easily enough to fill the little elf's heart with fear. But sat up there, upon the paradise island, it calmed so quick, as if the heated feeling had never come upon it. It watched in anticipation at the beings. It craved knowledge of all sorts, and the Dark Lands were a place most devoid of research, as the result of most expeditions usually tended to be death, even if a wizard or two were to be brought along for protection. So, with eyes focused and little pearly whites clenched, the elf began its own study.

The vileness of below reached it only in sight, but for a regal creature like an elf, that was nearly enough to send the contents of its stomach churning to the ground. It saw sights grotesque, like scavenging fiends partaking in rotting corpses of others. Sometimes it would find a sight most fear-inducing, such as when it saw the beast called Gargantuan, resting atop its hallowed out nest, in the midst of an active volcano. Routinely, it would start to spew pyres of molten red into the sky, nearly sending the elf reeling, despite not even reaching halfway between the ground and the island-cloud. Again, it would collect itself and gaze upon the Dark Lands with rapid anticipation. It saw that beast snoring soundly in the heart of the volcano, its skin not turning even the slightest bit red at the lava running around its entirety. As unbelievable as it may seem, the beast nearly did not fit in the volcano, needing to tuck its body in to just barely make it. Horribly large as it was, it became abundantly clear why so many expeditions to these Dark Lands had failed.

But that wasn't even the worst of it.

A dark and stormy sea stirred, like the large cauldron of a witch as it went to work brewing a vile concoction, blinding the elf with its aggressive tides. The island-cloud floated just above the stormy clouds that constantly raged above this region of the Dark Lands. The elf, finding its vision obscured, decided to move into the storm to get a better look at the landscape. In its mind, there shouldn't have been any sort of beast in the sky, never mind at the height he was at. So, it memorized the path of the island-cloud. It would be back in a few moments, minutes, maybe. Any longer would be asking for trouble. Fluttering down, the elf had to strain its little wings as it dove into the gray clouds. Deep, deeper, and deeper still, until finally it came to a place it could peer through the gray embrace, inches above where rain began to fall like bludgeoning weapons. And it was there that it heard the thunder, and from its periphery, the flash of lightning. It turned. The lightning flashed again, bluish amidst the rumbling nimbus hovering the quaking sea. The elf's heart paled like a vampire's, all the blood draining from its skin in an instant as it bore witness to what hid behind those ominous gray clouds. The only sound was the sonorous thunder's hammer, rushing over the elf's senses, yet unable to reach its mind.

For but a second, only in that mere moment, it had seen it. Hidden deep beneath the veil of clouds, a massive silhouette that blotted out the very skies, its wings outstretched heaven-bound, seeming the width of an entire castle wall, or more — and the fear that followed, easily the worst the little one had ever experienced, wrapping around the little elf's soul like a vice, constricting its thoughts. Motionless except for the flapping of its wings, the silken things continuously beating dully against the seething storm, the elf stared blankly at where that silhouette had been. It had known at once of what it saw, yet never did it stop to think of the sheer size of these legendary behemoths. Indeed texts by Man were correct, right and just as a stern jury in calling these beasts legendary. Their title was all deserved and more. Now, seeing one such beast of magnificent tales in person, the elf would have personally dubbed them mythical, though refrained as such tag was better applied to the hidden, for races such as druids, which could be found across many forests, but only if they so elected to show themselves, and those warm hobbits with an affinity for pies (elves too, of course).

Collecting itself, the elf surged back through the storm.

Tab 38

Wherever Light May Be, Darkness Breeds

There are a sort of man that dreadfully exist. For no matter the endeavors of them or their folk — and what a terrible hell it must be — to have their heads in constant turmoil; minds bothered, thoughts slaughtered, flashing images of hellish pyres. This, even when standing upon the grassy-golden plains of heaven.

Through eyes unsoiled:

Heartfully, I wept.

My boat swayed as it kept.

Dastardly shapes on the ketch.

Pain red like crude send.

The ice wept.

Solemnly my boat slid upon the waters.

Crystallion, it was —

Crystallion of the brightest hue.

Stars shined.

Grime marked my face.

Pale as should be.

And I wept.

Hurtfully, I wept.

My ketch stood the test of the rocking waves.

It did not cave, stilled and brave.

Water came aboard the deck.

It hopped on, weeping ever so quietly.

And I wept along with it.

The icy pieces crawled the mast like infection spreading.

How blue the scene was;

How it reminded me of "wept"

My song was sung of a sad moon.

Hanging above my shady head with eyes so bright.

Stars of rainy light.

The mast, icy-veined, swayed quietly on the waves.

Water was still.

The image was silent.

Yet I swore, before the brackish hue I could almost see:

Land, ahead of me.

And my ship wept.

Yearning for a brighter tomorrow.

As it swam desperately to the faraway shore.

Climbing past reefs protruding and rocks saluting.

My eyes were not teary, nor my breath weary, nor my gaze merely.

Merely saddened by the bow so strong.

Yet I wept.

I would weep as I approached the iron shore.

Ashen sands waved, brushing upon the vile deck of my ship.

Stray planks stuck into the yellow-grey stuff like tentacles.

Of a vile order.

Of a weeping brand.

My heart lurched with a weep.

It was so honest, so vulnerable.

So prone to emotion.

So prone to parlay.

And thus my boots sunk into the rotten sand.

Immobile, I was not.

Yet I stood, glued to the grain.

A sea of the deepest sand.

Strands of hair rolled off my shoulders.

Breeze lifted them up, and set them down.

Again it would occur.

Again I remained still.

Ice crackled in my ears, torching my very bones.

Splintering against my muscles.

Fibers of my being caught upon the morbid strings of a forever-weeping wooden violin.

Tightly woven strings of mortality.

They yearned;

Yearned.

Yearned for a day not spent weeping:

A day I would not seek "wept"

An hour I would not find sadness where relief is to be had.

A minute I would relish in hope.

A second my soul would not mope.

A moment —

A mere moment:

A moment I sought to hold as if it were dough.

Tab 39

Borderline Kraken

The pictures, azure pockets of memory. Tumultuous tides and a ravaged sea. Blasphemous rocking upon the ocean waves. A boat of long wooden planks, stitched together amateurishly. A crew of rugged children, sails bolstered upon their hearts. A voyage destined for failure.

Many a night, many a man. A cabbage soup and a sailor's hand. They were poor, they were. A boiling cesspool of carrot nor sand. It was marvelous, really, that their stomachs did not eat themselves, tired of long stints of endless hunger. Long time had gone, the sails with keep upon their hearts began to waver, the wind, their will and guide, beginning to die out.

A flame of sorrow. Not red, but blue and black. Extraordinarily bright.

Morbid, an ember of sentimental discussion. Rosaries upon rosaries of lies. A tailcoat jacket with buttons sowed meticulously. A cap with a feather through its roof. Half a mind to tell off the mass. Roars of orders spat to the sky. Heavens above knew of him, the captain of the azure galleon.

Though a sloop in his heart.

Never mind that. He was washed over by the smashing waters, a bluish green. Wet and uncomfortable. A chilly breeze splashed against his face, and the water was blown off. His hair was glued to his face grossly, covering his eyes. He swept it away with a cold finger.

The wood beneath his feet felt incredibly sturdy. Oak. Such a grand being. Those tall and sturdy oaks — his ship was crafted from such a mighty being. Alas, the waves seemed its bane. They crashed along its stern and its bow in equal, slamming the ship from tide to tide. A horrible storm of blows, leaving white marks down the ship's sides.

His face, marked by uncertainty, but lest did he allow it to show. Morale would dip, and that was key during these tumultuous times.

Steadfast his iron tendons were, tensing and loosening like a game of Tug-O-War. His eyes were a steely blue, and the oceans borne from his gaze held vises on his men. Metallic allure, a bronze wristwatch. Five to six. Heavens be to his side, his wretched teeth and malnourished hips.

The wind caught the sails and the vessel soared.

"Save our souls, she would ya lass!" the captain roared with renewed vigor. The ship rocked jovially in response, a stray spotlight falling upon the mast.

Again, he regaled, "Heathens be, a new fish we shall find and with it we shall catch."

“Yarr!” the crew cried. Pirates they were indeed.

And so the boat creaked, misty-eyed, it went. It lunged forward, breaking through the gales. The crew was bathed in a dewy glow as the sun broke through. A sight for eyes sore.

Stomachs so tangled let go their locks, and deposited their insides overboard. Eyes stood childlike upon their captain, trust stalwart. For his mettle was that which was dipped in glory, the deepest molten core. A star, he was, amidst the roaming seas.

“Golden sea dog!” they would cry. “Oh, captain, my captain!”

His chest, though meager and scrawny, was a metallic synergy of gold and silver. He was their guiding light, shining through blinding waves of blue and white. Their praise reached his ears, and he smiled larger than a chest of gold could open, lips blue and black — touched by that same sorrowful flame.

Suddenly, the boat lurched and a fog dropped.

“Land ho!” they all cheered.

Their boots crammed together before the bulwark as they launched from the ship, landing delicately in the hot sand. They left marks as they trudged up the shore, into the green thicket. Navy flowers wrapped around the trees in poisonous jubilee, tempting hands to their death-claiming bodies. One idiot tried his luck with the plant; oh, how hungry he was. His veins bulged and a surge of fear shot through him. Just as the captain, last to leave the boat as they do, touched upon the sandy shore, the crew mate fell ill and dropped to the forest floor. His extremities were blacked and disgusting. Quickly, his former friends rolled him to the side, pushing him into a hole. One or two shed a tear, alas he was an idiot, so many figured this end just.

How funny it is that death comes quickly for some, yet waits a lifetime for others.

Only the azure memories, their deep pockets. Only justice prevailed when judged. At least that was what the captain sought. But neither heaven nor heathen carried worthy answers. Neither ship nor sail, or annihilation upon the great blue — a seaworthy vessel caked in white crustaceans hanging by a thread.

Docking their large ship, the men shivered as night approached. They worked quickly to design a fire and a warm place to rest. The bushes rumbled with anticipation, and all eyes shot to them immediately. It was a bunny, white as night, with eyes red. Lusting for blood. Or was it they who carried such a lust? Did it matter?

The answer: it did not.

They pounced on it immediately, as if wild beasts. A savage image of locked arms and desperate claws was painted. The bunny had become contested territory, its red eyes flashing a somber blue as its life faded into nothing.

A few moments into the clambering mess of starvation, a voice rang out, instantly bringing the sound to a lull. "Gentlemen!" the captain shouted. "We may be pirates with a lust for savagery, gold and all sorts of other delicious treasures running through our veins. But we are not animals. Now, quit this fighting and mend the fire!"

With a violent gesture and a raised tone, the men hurriedly dismounted each other. Though that savage light remained, a hidden ruby beneath their irises, the men knew not to disobey their captain. Even if their stomachs wanted to.

The captain nodded. His palms stuck into the sand and he pushed himself up from beside the fire, walked around it, and kneeled beside the massacred chunks of the late bunny. His face was expressionless.

He picked up a piece of it. Flesh matted with fresh blood which drizzled past his thumb. Cold.

Soft, too.

Fur white as snow.

He held the sorry bunny's remains for a moment more. He could not help but think of what it would feel like to be dogpiled by a crew of disheveled men, crushed beneath their weight and ripped to pieces beneath their claws. It must feel horrible — it must have felt horrible.

He sighed, closing his eyes.

It was unimportant now, he supposed.

Suddenly, a bony hand poked his shoulder, spooking him. "Cap'n," the hand said, "we are hungry."

The captain lowered his hand and placed the bunny's flesh on the ground. "Of course. Gather 'round, and we shall cook this bunny. First come, first serve."

And so they did as such.

Alas, there was little food to gain from a slaughtered bunny, and only a quarter of the crew had been fed by the end. The captain scratched his chin in thought. Stomachs groaned painfully around him.

Making up his mind, he looked to his crew, and spoke, "Those that have been fed," he pointed to the depths of the forest, unlit by the fiery glow of the campfire, "are to follow me into the woods. We will acquire rations for the rest of the crew."

The quarter that had been fed nodded. Though, a few did whisper some denials or try to hide, but those few quickly had a change of mind when the captain's fist raised before their face. "Ye were fed, time to feed those who haven't such a luxury. We go at once."

The captain's boots left sandy imprints leading into the dark forest. Branches hung low overhead, and were nearly caught upon by each member of the expedition. Some tripped on the low roots that wiggled beneath their feet as if alive. Some were frightened by the darkness of the forest, yet followed their captain anyway.

It was not long before they reached a clearing. Upon arrival, the captain turned around and spoke to the men, "Split and look for food. Happen upon a peach tree or perhaps one of coconut, alert me of its location."

A calm gesture later, the men had found the tree. It was not too large, but it was one that would feed the entire crew, if not for a few nights. One man stuffed a peach into his pocket and made off into the shadow of the night with it. His absence was not recorded, and his disappearance went unnoticed. He would be glad he did.

The captain looked for a moment before spying a green rope. Some swinging vine. He yanked it from a branch, though with some effort, and tied it around the peach tree. Tugging once, he saw that it was held firm. Even if stormy bellows threatened the tree, the rope would hold. Satisfied, he led his men back through the forest. Crickets chirped in their ears, and frogs echoed their "ribbits" through the calm branches. The moon shone brightly above.

A calm blue with a white lens.

It looked like a gold coin, or a wheel of cheese, maybe?

The men stepped past the last ingrown root and reached the campfire once more.

The captain rubbed his eyes tiredly, releasing a yawn. "Those who are hungry," he yawned again, "follow me."

The forest shook suddenly. Violently. The captain nearly lost his balance.

"Wha—"

He looked back. His eyes widened. It was a scene he would never forget.

Large grotesque tentacles lashed out from the sea. They dwarfed even his largest man in size. Stunned silent, the captain could only watch in shock as a different tentacle grabbed each one of his men, dragging them into the black abyss.

Their faces carried fear. Deep surprise scarred their final moments.

Below, the sea churned with maniacal fury. A storm approached before he could react. Rain slammed against his back, but he remained in place.

He looked back warily. Though the fire was extinguished, he could still see.

But what did it matter to see if there was nothing to look at?

Saliva packed together and pushed down his throat.

Empty.

That was the only word that came to mind. His entire crew had disappeared, and he had a good idea as to where. He gazed at the black depths silently. He still had not eaten, but he could not care less. His mind was completely focused on one thing:

The image of those daunting tentacles, large enough to capsize a boat.

This thought led him to check, and yes, his ship had also disappeared. The culprit was obvious. Still, just what, or who, was the culprit?

It had... tentacles. So, octopus? Squid?

"Giant squid..." he muttered indistinctly, teeth chattering madly.

A songbird sang from the murky forest depths, yet its beautiful melody disdained touch upon his ears.

Tweet, tweet.

Night came and went silently, without argument, yet he remained stationary. Unmoving, but constantly thinking. His boots were bolted to the ground tightly. His thoughts slammed him from all sides, and the harrowing image continued to resurface as if haunting him. He hated it.

He hated it so much.

So.

Damn.

Much.

His eyes filled with water, and his tears finally began to shed. Penance was long overdue. Painfully, he mourned the loss of his crew. It hit him hard, harder than anything had ever hit him. Why, just why, was he cursed to this fate?

Why did the tentacle leave?

Why didn't it take him with it?

His nose twitched as memory-laden tears trickled over, falling off its bridge. He sniffled. Tears like salt, traveling past his chin, down his neck, over his gold-embedded shark tooth

necklace, down his hairy torso, his scarred chest, over his prominent ribs, his bony waist and protruding hips, until finally trailing down his pant legs and dribbling into the yellow sand, painting it brown. His tears were cold, blue. They were the sky, they were the sea.

They were azure.

Pockets of memory held in their aquatic glow.

Glistening pictures.

A crew and their captain.

Tab 40

America

When the crickets sing their solemn croaks,
voices ringing out in blotted skies.

The clouds huddle over with disgraceful plight,
tyranny on display in the world,
whom shall prevail?

Now, deer cry for democracy and frogs dream of monarchy,
yet no two may remain under veil,
for with the coming of the galleon,
and the sailing of the sloop,
the land has been tamed,
Jamestown, Plymouth, and Salem, too.